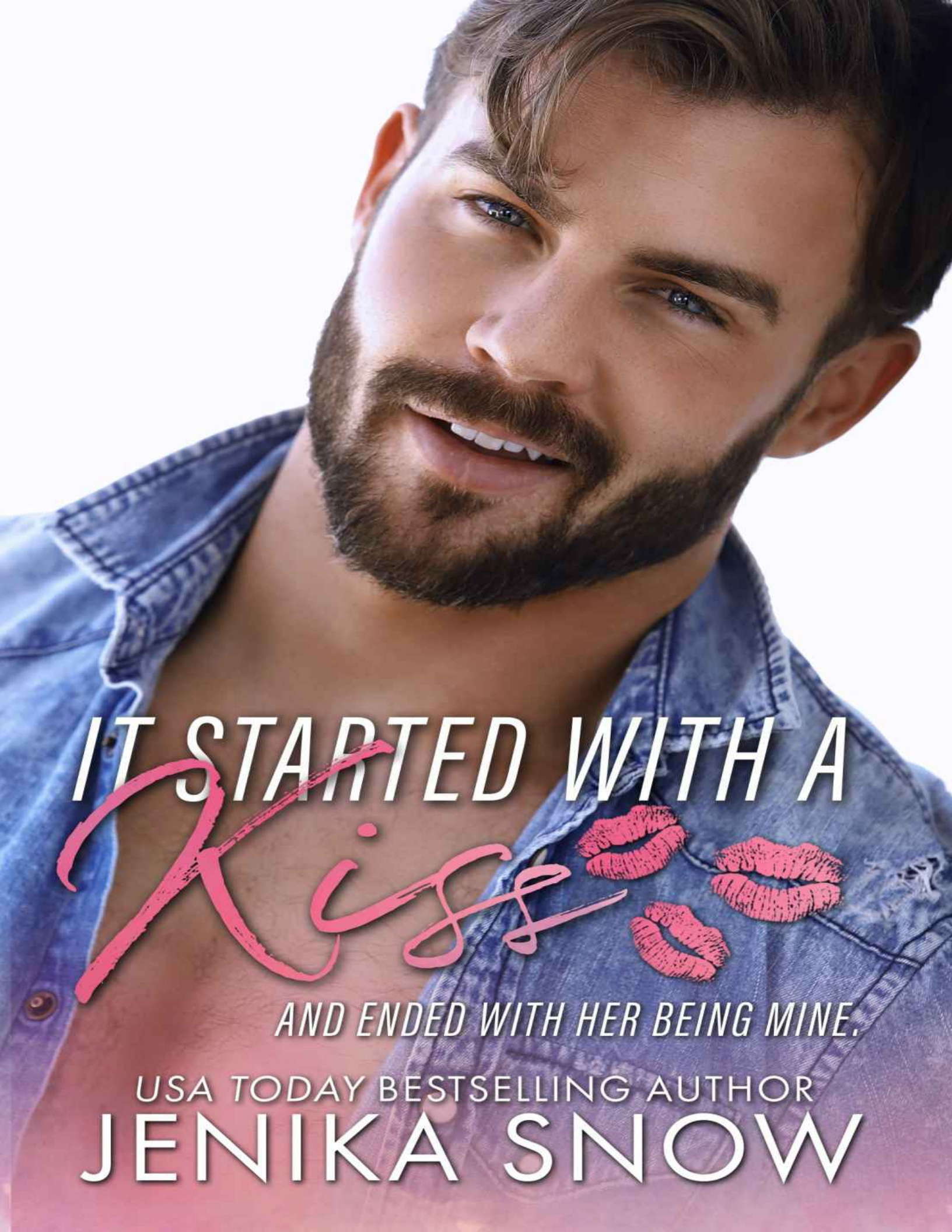
IT STARTED WITH A
Kiss
AND ENDED WITH HER BEING MINE.
USA TODAY BESTSELLING AUTHOR
JENIKA SNOW

IT STARTED WITH A KISS

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IT STARTED WITH A KISS

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Ari

It was supposed to be a fun, easygoing bachelorette party. But it turned out to be so much more.

They dared me to kiss the next guy to buy me a drink. And I agreed. It was just a kiss, right?

And then it happened... I saw Grey and felt something instant.

I tried to back out of that kiss even though I wanted it desperately.

But he didn't let me stop it. He kissed me until my toes curled and my heart raced. He kissed me until I knew I wanted more.

So when I left him standing there staring at me, I knew it was all kinds of wrong to leave.

Grey

It started with a dare.

It ended with a kiss.

And for weeks after she walked out of my life, I searched for her, doing anything and everything in my power to find a morsel of information about the first woman to make my heart stop and my future flash before my eyes.

And when I finally found her, I was going to show Ari that I'd known she was mine from the very beginning.

And that I wasn't letting her go a second time.

Chapter One

Ari

"Shot. Shot. Shot. Shot."

I tried to tune out the three already heavily intoxicated women shouting in my ear like they were at a frat party.

I lifted up the tiny glass and eyed the colored liquor inside. My stomach already clenched in queasiness.

"Don't bitch out now, Ari."

I narrowed my eyes at Francesca, or Franny as we called her, the bride-to-be and resident instigator of our little group.

"You can't be sober at a bachelorette party," Bernadette said. "I think that's some kind of sin or something."

"Yeah, no party poopers tonight," Kai responded, then promptly giggled.

I snorted. "One of us should keep a clear head, right?"

The girls booed, and I glanced around, giving sympathetic looks to everyone around us. We were being loud, they were drunk, and no doubt the people around us thought we were a bunch of idiots.

But when I looked at Franny and saw what a good time she was having, I said fuck it. Let them be loud. Let us be obnoxious. And for once in my life—at least for tonight—I was hanging up my literal librarian persona and letting loose.

I tossed the shot back and the girls clapped and cheered. The alcohol burned down my throat, settling in my stomach so it felt like a lead ball. I wheezed and coughed, my eyes watering, and

reached for a glass of water. After I sucked that down, I was reminded why I didn't really drink. It made my face red, I was one hell of a lightweight, and my hangovers were pretty horrendous.

But this was a once in a while type of thing, celebrating with my friend before she got married, so what's the worst that could happen?

"What's new in the dating world with you?" Franny asked and picked up her beer, taking a long drink from it as she watched me over the rim, expectant of my answer.

I shook my head, not even wanting to go there. "What dating world?"

"Girl," Franny said and started laughing. "We need to get you out there so you can get that V card punched."

I rolled my eyes at her library reference.

I might be a librarian, but even I found it corny.

"Yeah, we need to get that V card punched real good."

I glanced around, Franny's drunkenness making her especially loud. A few guys looked over at us, one grinning and the other wagging his eyebrows.

Yeah. Hard no, boys.

I might have been a virgin, have the whole tight bun and schoolteacher look going on, but I wasn't so desperate to get rid of my virginity that I'd give it away to some drunken asshole.

"Oh my God," Lizzie said, her eyes wide as she looked between us. "I have the best idea." She was already three sheets to the wind and there was no stopping or slowing her down. None of them.

"By the look on your face, I can see it's a really bad idea," I said and leaned back against the chair, afraid to hear this.

"Ari, to make things fun, spice it up, I dare you to kiss the next guy who buys you a drink."

I was shaking my head before she even finished talking. "Nope. I'll get some gross asshole. That would be my luck." I looked at the guys who'd been eyeing me after overhearing the whole V card conversation with Franny.

They were grinning at me.

I internally cringed.

"Come on," Bernadette pleaded. "Not like you'll ever see them again. It's all in good fun."

"Besides, you're never able to let loose. Tonight is the first time in what, like forever that you let your hair down? Literally." Franny held up her shot glass and grinned.

"What they said," Kai said and hiccupped.

I was going to say no again, but as I looked at my three best friends, saw them grinning and pleading, I knew they were right, that I didn't let loose, that most times I did have a stick up my ass. It had been forever since I let myself enjoy just being out... just being alive.

It was just a kiss, right? But under no circumstance was I going to accept a drink from the creepers sitting at the table beside us who'd overheard the conversation.

"Okay, fine," I said, and the girls started clapping even louder. "I can handle a kiss from a stranger, but I reserve the right to turn him down."

The girls started shaking their heads. "Nope, a dare is a dare."

"What if he's like sixty?"

Franny shrugged. "Does the saying about getting better with age count toward dick too?"

I nearly spit out the water I'd been about to swallow.

"Come on. One kiss to the next guy who buys you a drink," Bernadette and Kai said in unison.

I exhaled and sat back in my chair. "Fine. I accept the challenge."

Chapter Two

Grey

I ’d noticed her from the moment she came into the bar. She’d been surrounded by three other women, all of them looking like her opposite.

Damn, she stood out in this place, and that was one hell of a good thing.

I sat in the corner of Maxine’s, a local sports bar that brought in a lot of kids from the college in town. It had been here since before I was a kid, but over the years and massive renovations, it started bringing in and catering to the younger group of residents in the town of Lockdown. But it was still the place I came on occasion after work. It was either come here or go home alone, and the latter was getting pretty fucking tiring.

I watched her from my darkened corner, some new pop song playing from the speakers. But everything else faded away as I continued to stare at her.

She and the friends she was with made their way to a table, one of the women wearing those “Bride to Be” sashes. They all wore slinky dresses... lots of skin showing.

But not her, not the woman I was transfixed with, not the one I couldn’t take my eyes off of. She wasn’t wearing anything revealing, and I fucking loved that.

She had her long dark hair in a low ponytail, her bangs swept to the side, her black-rimmed glasses feminine and innocent looking. I was obsessed with her and I knew nothing about her.

And every time she took her little finger and pushed those glasses up the brim of her nose, every part of my body tightened. She wore a pair of jeans and a cardigan set. Compared to the other girls she was with—fuck, every female in this bar on a Saturday night—she was dressed modestly,

respectfully.

Although I didn't give two shits about what anyone wore and would've loved fucking seeing her in hardly anything at all, I liked that she was covered up. It made it so no other fuckers in this bar could see her. And that fact had my instant jealousy calming minutely.

I was close enough to them that I could hear their conversation. The girls were rather loud and the music aimed more toward the center of the bar, so that helped as well. I shouldn't have been eavesdropping, but I couldn't help it.

I curled my hands into fists on top of the table, the very idea of someone taking her, claiming her as their own doing something primal to me. I'd never felt this way before, never been so enamored, possessive... *obsessed* with anyone in my life. I didn't know her, but from the moment I saw her, I knew one thing—I wanted her as mine.

I wasn't your normal kind of man, didn't go off and fuck random women to let off steam. I focused on my life, on working and doing better for myself. I'd focused on getting my degree, creating my own business, on bettering the things around me. And because of that, my social life had suffered, as had my romantic one.

And I was fine with that.

Thirty-five years old and celibate for the last decade. That's how seriously I took all of this. And I was completely content with not having a woman to warm my bed. Because I knew once I gave myself to someone again, it would be forever.

Monogamy was what I wanted, exclusivity.

And as I'd seen her walk through that door, as I felt something stir deep inside me, something I had never experienced before, I knew I'd found the woman who was meant to be mine.

I brought my beer bottle up to my mouth and took a slow, long drink from it, watching her, memorizing the little mannerisms she did. Her cheeks were flushed, and they'd become that way after she'd taken that shot. I wondered what other part of her body flushed, was all pretty and pink.

Fuck. My jeans were getting tighter the longer I stared at her, the more I thought about her blushing for me.

I wanted to settle down, wanted a wife and children, wanted that white picket fucking fence. I wanted the American dream. And I told myself, promised myself I wouldn't be one of the stereotypical men who whored around.

I promised myself I'd be completely faithful until I found her. The one. And I had. Right now.

"The next guy who offers to buy you a drink, Ari, you have to kiss him," one of the girls dared her, and I sat up straighter.

Ari.

Her name had adrenaline rushing through my veins, had my pants tightening even more as my cock thickened. Fuck, I wanted her.

And my chance had just opened up, as if fate was giving me the green light to make my move.

I saw a couple guys sitting next to the women perk up, no doubt hearing the same thing. This low, aggressive sound left me and I slowly stood, staring at them. They glanced my way as if sensing me, like prey knowing when a predator was near. They were nothing but punks, so when I slowly shook my head, silently warning them not to even think about buying that fucking drink, I saw them instantly back down.

They straightened and averted their gaze from mine, their surrender pleasing me.

Assholes.

I sat back down and waved the server over.

“Bring her over a beer and let her know it’s from me,” I said and pointed to Ari.

Once the server left, I turned my focus back on Ari, staring at her face, waiting to see her expression. The server set the beer in front of her and pointed in my direction. She glanced over her shoulder at me, her eyes widening, her friends trying to suppress their excitement.

Maybe it was a shit thing to do, buying her that drink because I knew she’d kiss me for it. But I was desperate for her and would do just about anything. Besides, this seemed like a better introduction than me being one of those dicks who tried to talk to her at a bar because I wanted in her pants.

I had a hand wrapped around my beer bottle, the other resting on my thigh. I knew shadows partially obscured me, but the longer she stared at me, right in my eyes, I knew she saw me well enough.

And the longer I looked at her, our eyes locked on each other, the more I knew she was definitely mine. She’d been made just for me. It was crazy, I admitted, to have feelings for a woman I didn’t even know, to feel so connected to her, so possessive of her. But I went with my gut instinct, and it was telling me that I had to have her, that I had to make her see we belonged together.

So if I got a little dirty in my tactics in how I got that introduction, so be it. I’d do anything, everything, to feel like this for the rest of my life.

She turned back toward her friends, and they started saying something softly to each other, one of them unable to stop grinning. They kept glancing over to me, one of them even gently nudging Ari in my direction.

It took her a few moments, but she finally stood, grabbing the beer I’d bought her and heading over. Her steps were slow, a little bit hesitant. I could see she was nervous, saw the way her pulse beat frantically below her ear. That pleased me to know she was so innocent, that this wasn’t something she normally did.

And then she stood right in front of my table, neither one of us saying anything, her fingers picking at the label on the beer bottle. I could practically see her heart racing, beating almost violently right beneath her slender frame.

“You bought me this drink?” she asked softly.

I didn’t answer for a suspended moment, just took her in, her slender form, her perky little breasts. God, her nipples were hard, pressing against the cream-colored material of her cardigan set.

Then I nodded. “I hope that’s okay.”

She glanced down at the beer she held then looked at me again. She had the clearest, bluest eyes I’d ever seen, and with her dark hair, it was a startling, gorgeous contrast.

She nodded, licked her lips, and glanced at her friends. “Um, actually—”

I tried to suppress my smile, because I knew what she was going to say, going to do.

She was going to follow through with that dare.

Chapter Three

Ari

Lord. I was actually going to go through with this. Or maybe I wasn't. Maybe I should just come clean, tell him, and then go back there and tell the girls he declined, that he didn't want a kiss.

But as I looked back at him, this handsome stranger with the short, sandy brown hair, the trimmed beard, and bright blue eyes, a part of me wanted to go through with the dare. But this wasn't me. This wasn't who I was, despite the little buzz I felt from that shot I'd done.

"Listen," I said and exhaled. "My friends dared me to kiss the next guy who bought me a drink." I held up the beer bottle. "And that was you." I was so embarrassed right now, felt my cheeks heat. "But I'm not the type of girl to just kiss strangers, so I'll go back there and just say you declined."

He didn't say anything, just picked up his beer and took a long drink from it, watching me the whole time. I couldn't explain his expression, but I felt it, literally felt it move through me. It was as if he touched every single part of me, his fingers moving along my body. Goose bumps popped out on my arms, and the tiny hairs on the back of my neck stood up.

I was about to turn around and head back to the table when he got up, moved around the table to where I stood, and stopped a foot from me. I had to crane my neck back just to look in his face.

It was clear he worked out, but he wasn't the gym rat type of guy. No, I could tell he did hard, manual labor, could see the calluses on his hands, imagining what they'd feel like on my body. Maybe he did construction or something along those lines.

All I knew was it made me feel very feminine standing beside him.

"So—" That word became lodged in my throat. "—I know this is awkward…." Before I could

finish, he reached out and slipped his hand along the side of my face, smoothed his finger against my cheekbone, and leaned in. I held my breath when I felt his lips touch mine. I should have pulled back, stopped it, but I found myself closing my eyes and leaning into him.

He made this gruff sound in the back of his throat and stroked his tongue along the seam of my lips, and I opened for him, running on instinct, needing this like I needed to breathe.

He slipped his other hand around my waist, digging his fingers into my body, pulling me in closer. And when I felt his tongue add pressure to my mouth, I opened for him instantly.

I'd never been kissed like this, never felt this kind of desire. And I swore that as we kissed for long minutes, the world faded away, that it was just him and me.

The feeling of his tongue moving along mine had a soft moan leaving me. I couldn't have stopped it even if I wanted to. He broke the kiss, his fingers lightly skimming my skin as he moved his hand away from my face. But I swore I felt those tingles along every erogenous zone in my body.

The way I was breathing should have embarrassed me. It was like I'd just run a marathon... or had sex.

"I'm Ari," I said, my voice breathy, my eyes closed, and my heart racing. I could taste him on my tongue, this bittersweet hop flavor that had me thirsty for more.

"Look at me." His voice was low, so low only I could hear. But there was command laced in it, one I couldn't not obey.

And when I opened my eyes and stared into his, I got lost in the blue depths. We stared at each other for long moments, and as much as I wanted another kiss, I found myself taking a step back. I was overwhelmed, consumed with need, passion... confusion.

"I'm sorry," I whispered, lifting my hand and touching my fingers to my lips, feeling his mouth still on me.

"I'm not," he replied, but there was no smugness in his tone. He looked serious. He looked as consumed as I felt. "I'm Grey."

God, his voice was deep, so masculine that I involuntarily curled my fingers into my palm, my nails pricking my skin. Even his name was all man.

I licked my lips, tasting him, wanting another kiss and almost ready to take that step forward once more.

"On to the next joint," I heard Franny say, far closer than she'd been just moments ago.

I looked to the side and saw all three girls standing there staring at us with open mouths and wide eyes. They were either shocked I'd gone through with it and actually done the kiss, or they'd been able to feel the chemistry and passion as much as I had.

"Yeah, the night's not getting any younger," Kai said, and I didn't miss how she glanced at Grey.

I looked over at him and saw he his attention was still trained right on me. His expression was focused... possessive. There was no other word I could use for the way he made me feel as he looked at me.

"I…" I didn't want to go. I wanted to learn more about him. I wanted to feel him again, next to me, kissing me, his hands on my body. I wanted it all. But common sense and rationalization rose up. I didn't know him. This was a dare kiss, and he was probably staring at me like that because he thought I'd jump right in bed with him now.

And the truth was, I probably would have.

Before I could say anything else, one of the girls had hold of my hand and was all but pulling me out of the bar. And the entire time I couldn't help but watch him as I left, everything in me screaming to go back.

* * *

Grey

I stood there and watched her leave despite every single part of my body wanting to go to her. I could still feel my mouth on hers, could feel my hand on her waist, the desire to pull her in close riding me hard. But I'd kept myself in check. If I'd pressed my body to hers—like I'd wanted to—she'd no doubt feel the hard ridge of my cock pressing against my jeans.

And I sure as hell didn't want her thinking I was some horned-up asshole just wanting to fuck her.

I let her walk away, because I was in this haze as we stared into each other's eyes, her friends pulling her out the front doors, probably shocked as hell at the scene they'd just witnessed.

Hell, I'd been unable to control myself. I should've just accepted her excuse and let her friends think I didn't want the kiss. It would have been a fucking lie, but it probably would have made things less complicated.

When she was out the door and the spell she had over me was broken, I reached out and placed a hand on the table, steadying myself.

Ari.

Her name played through my head over and over again.

"Ari." It rolled off my tongue, sounding fucking perfect.

I knew one thing for certain—there was no way I was going to let Ari walk out of my life.

No fucking way. That kiss was only the first step in me claiming her.

Chapter Four

Ari

One week later

I should've been working, not staring at my computer screen, the library catalogue spread out on the Excel sheet, the whole thing looking foreign because my mind was currently on one thing.

One person.

Grey.

It had been a week since I'd been at the bar, since he'd kissed me. Yet I still felt like I was right in front of him.

I lifted my fingers and touched my lips, even now still feeling him there, tasting him on my mouth.

When my friends had dragged me out of the bar, everything in me wanted to dig my heels into the ground and stay. And the rational part of my brain told me that wasn't logical. We didn't know each other, it had been a dare kiss, and he'd probably just done it to help me save face in front of my friends.

That, and what guy turned down a random kiss?

Maybe he'd just been one of those drunken guys at the bar who'd take anything and everything a woman would give? It was totally possible.

But even thinking that, I knew it wasn't the case. I knew nothing about Grey aside from his first name, but I felt something more. That sensation when I'd first seen him had been so profound, so intense that even now I still felt it. It poured through my veins, through my bloodstream, growing stronger each day.

I'd never felt like this before, never experienced anything so... consuming.

Someone came up to the counter and asked for a book, and I was forced to push anything Grey related out of my head. But that was easier said than done. Realistically, I knew the chances of seeing him again were pretty slim. And that sucked.

I didn't know his last name, didn't know anything about him. But if I did, I knew I would have probably stalked his fine ass.

For all I knew, he could've been passing through, not even a resident of town. And although our city wasn't exactly small and there were plenty of people I didn't know, I'd never met before, surely I would've seen him around?

Certainly a man like him who gave me butterflies in my stomach from just a look, who had my pulse racing, who had me wanting more in life, fate would've thrown in my direction from the beginning, right?

Or maybe it was all in my head and my infatuation for him was just strong.

What I did know, what I was sure about, was I had to get Grey out of my head. I had to go on with my life and forget what we'd shared.

It was just a kiss, after all.

---

* * *

Grey

"You realize this is like, illegal and shit, right?" Camden glanced over at me. He sat behind his computer desk, the curious and skeptical expression on his face not fazing me. "Not to mention, it's creepy and stalkerish."

I narrowed my eyes at him. "Just do it. I'm desperate, dude."

He shrugged and faced his computer again, his fingers flying over the keyboard. "I mean, she must have really gotten into your head for you to go to these lengths."

Yeah, that was an understatement.

"And you only know her first name?"

"Yeah," I said, having been thinking that name over and over again for the last week. I lifted a hand and ran it over my jaw, smoothing my palm over my beard.

The sound of Camden's fingers still typing at the keys filled the small apartment.

I'd known Camden for the last fifteen years. We'd gone to college together, hated one another at first because we were so damn alike, but we'd grown on each other.

Where I got my business degree, he'd gone and became some damn computer genius. Now he owned his own security company, had all kinds of access to shit. Not to mention, he was like one of those next-level hacker brainiacs if it came down to it.

So here I was, asking him to do definitely illegal shit, because I was that consumed with Ari.

"What was her name again? Andi?"

"Ari," I said and nearly groaned just from saying her fucking name.

"Ari, that's right," he replied almost absentmindedly. He went back to typing. "This could take a while, man. Ari is kind of an unusual name, but shit, it's not like she's the only one out there. You know what I mean?" He glanced over at me, his short dark hair perfectly styled.

He had a surfer boy vibe going on. Olive skin with blue eyes. Short hair that was perpetually mussed as if he'd just come from the fucking beach or some shit.

But behind all of that, Camden was the smartest fucker I knew. Like scary smart. And that's why I'd come to him when I'd exhausted my own efforts.

I stared at him for the next five minutes, watching him work, seeing the concentration on his face. But impatience grew in me. "Camden, man, how much longer?"

He looked at me, one eyebrow raised. "Seriously? When I said it was gonna take me a while, that's what I meant. I can't find information like this on someone, with only a first name to go off of, in a couple minutes."

Fuck.

"I'm talking about doing some deep digging, going through files, social media, searching back alley programs. I need a couple days at least." I gritted my teeth at that. "Besides, I have to be careful, Grey. What I'm doing could get me thrown in jail. I gotta make sure I cover my tracks, you know?"

I exhaled in frustration but nodded in surrender. "Yeah."

It had been seven days too long since I'd seen Ari, and I was growing desperate to find her.

Camden leaned back in his chair, the leather creaking softly. "Why don't you work out or something? Go running or lift weights, get rid of some of that nervous energy you clearly have going on right now."

I ran my hand over the back of my head.

"Besides, it'll suck up some time and maybe get your mind off this shit."

Yeah, that wasn't going to happen.

"I'll call you as soon as I have anything on her."

I didn't want to leave until I had what I'd come here for, but Camden had a point. He had to do his thing, and I couldn't rush him. He was doing me a massive solid as it was.

I stood, knowing I'd be harassing his ass because I wanted this information.

"Grey?"

I was heading toward his front door but then stopped and turned to face him. "Yeah?"

He looked at his computer screen for a second before glancing back at me. "Did she screw you over or something? Is this some kind of revenge thing?"

I was close to Camden, considered him family. But I found myself fiercely protective of information regarding Ari—the information about how I felt for her. Still, he was doing me a massive favor, not even really asking any questions, and I knew I had to be honest with him. I owed it to him for putting his neck on the line for me.

He deserved so much more than me pounding on his door all but demanding information on a woman because I'd come up empty-handed in my search over the last week.

I exhaled and shoved my hands in the front pockets of my jeans. "I met her last week. I kissed her.

And since then, I haven't been able to get her out of my mind." I shook my head slowly.

"Man, you obsessed with her or something?"

"Or something," I murmured. "I've never felt like this before about anyone. Just thinking about her, Camden, just picturing her out there with other men looking at her, talking to her, hell, even thinking about her…" I shook my head again as anger started to rise. "It pisses me off, because I want to be the only man who gets to do any of that."

Camden was quiet for a few seconds after I spoke, but then he whistled low. "Damn, Grey."

Yeah, that summed it up.

"This is all over some kiss?"

I guess in the grand scheme of things maybe it was, but it was also about that first look, the first scent of her perfume, or that first touch of my fingers on her cheek.

"It started as that, but it's so much more, Camden. I need to find her, need to see if she feels the same way I do. Until I find that out—"

"And what if she's not feeling it like you do? You gonna walk away?"

I didn't even need to think about it.

I slowly shook my head. "No, I can't walk away."

This was my obsession.

She was my obsession.

Chapter Five

Ari

"I pray like hell I'm not bloated and on my period on my wedding day," Franny said as she looked at herself in the full-length mirror at the bridal dress shop.

All of us had come along for final alterations, and as I sat and waited for the sales associate to bring me my bridesmaid dress, staring at Franny and her gorgeous white gown, once again I was left thinking about Grey. I'd gotten to the point where it was almost laughable, and a little bit ridiculous that I was so fixated on him.

I shifted on the plush leather chair and looked over at Kai and Bernadette, who were looking at tiaras and jewelry. I hadn't spoken to the girls about any of this, and aside from when they pulled me out of the bar, they hadn't mentioned one word about Grey.

Then again, they probably didn't care. They had been drunk and had only seen this random, kind of awkward exchange between two strangers. So why would they ask me about it?

But a part of me wanted to talk to them about it, to see if they thought I was being crazy or if I should explore this, find out more about him. But how exactly would I do that? Go to the bar and start asking around? Like anyone there would know. Like anyone there had probably even been sober enough that night to know who the hell I was talking about.

Franny cleared her throat and turned around so she could face me, the podium she was on slightly elevated so that her gown hung freely without dragging on the floor. It was a strapless cut with crystal detailing around the bodice and along the bottom hem.

I got lost in that dress, following each little crystal, trying to keep my mind off what I really

wanted to have it occupy.

Grey.

“I meant to ask you,“ Franny said as she looked down at her dress, smoothing her hands over it. “I mean, it’s all a little fuzzy, but I’ve been thinking about that guy you kissed at the bar.”

I straightened in my chair and looked at her before glancing at the other girls.

“You’ve been thinking about him?” I prompted almost absentmindedly.

She looked up at me and nodded, her brows furrowed before she grinned. “Yeah, and I have no idea why.” She shrugged, the smile still in place. “Maybe because he was so good looking, or maybe…” She stared me right in the eyes. “Maybe it was the fact that the kiss you guys shared seemed pretty intense. And like, the hottest thing I ever freaking saw.” She was momentarily distracted as a sales associate came by with some pins and started folding up the material so it was snugger around her body.

I couldn’t think, couldn’t even calm my breathing for that matter.

“Or maybe I saw more into it than there actually was, given the fact that you look like I’ve lost my damn mind.”

My hands started to get clammy, and my pulse raced. Could I even be honest with her? Could I really tell her that I’d been thinking about Grey seemingly every minute of every day since our encounter last week?

They’d think I was insane, obsessive even.

“Hey, are you okay?” Franny asked, looking concerned.

This was my best friend. All three of them were.

And as I looked at Kai and Bernadette, who now turned their attention to us, clearly hearing the conversation, I reminded myself these three were like family. They’d been with me through thick and thin and would never judge me.

So I took a deep breath and just said what I’d wanted to from the moment I left that bar. “Honestly?” Kai and Bernadette were already beside me, and Franny stepped down from the podium. And as I looked between the three of them, I felt a sense of relief at the fact that I’d finally be honest about it, that I’d finally get these words out to somebody other than myself. “The truth is, I’ve been thinking about him since you guys pulled me out of the bar.” My lips tingled at the thought of that kiss, as I thought about how much more I wanted from him.

Everyone stayed silent, and the only thing I could hear was the rushing of the blood through my veins and the low sound of the jazz playing overheard through the speakers.

“And it was intense.” I swallowed, my mouth dry, my throat tight. “It was the most intense kiss I think I’ll ever experience in my life. And it wasn’t the alcohol or the situation. It wasn’t even the kind of forbidden aspect of kissing a stranger.” I thought about that night once more. “It was this connection I felt with him, the way it felt to have his fingers on my skin, this electricity moving through me as he touched me almost innocently, like he thought I’d break.” God, I was going on about it like some schoolgirl, like I was in some kind of romance novel.

This kind of stuff didn’t happen in real life. At least, it had never happened to me.

After I was finished speaking, I realized the girls had said nothing in response. All three were staring at me, their eyes slightly wide, their mouths a little bit parted.

“Oh shit,” Kai said.

“Wow,” Bernadette whispered after that.

“Um, talk about making all other kisses seem like shit.” Franny looked at me like I’d had some elusive, mythical experience. “I mean, don’t get me wrong, I love how Braden kisses me, but shit, I

don't think I've ever experienced anything like that."

I cleared my throat and rubbed my palms up and down my jeans. "I'm losing my mind, aren't I?"

Kai and Bernadette had big grins spread across their faces.

"I told you guys it was something more than just a dare." Kai looked between all of us, a smug expression on her face. "I told you we shouldn't have pulled her out of the bar, that we should have just let things play out."

"If I'm being honest, watching that hot guy kiss you the way he did gave me more excitement than I have had in a hell of a long time, even with Braden," Franny confessed with this dreamlike expression on her face.

Everyone started laughing, and I felt my face heat.

"I second and third that shit," Bernadette said.

We didn't say anything else for long seconds, and I felt tension fill me, but it wasn't the bad kind, more the expectant, excited kind.

"So I'm not crazy? I'm not losing my mind?" I looked at all of them. "You guys saw there was something between us too?" I sat up taller, my back ramrod-straight now.

When they were silent for a little too long, I started to worry once more, embarrassed that I'd said anything, because surely wanting a man this much wasn't normal.

But then all three of them slowly shook their heads.

"Crazy?"

"Losing your mind?"

"You'd be stupid not to go after him," they all said one right after the other, and I couldn't help but chuckle softly.

"Girl, go get your man before someone else snatches that fine ass up." Kai grinned. "And I don't mean his fine *ass* either."

Bernadette and Franny started laughing.

And right then, I felt my confidence grow. I felt like all these puzzle pieces just fell right into place. They were right. I was going after Grey and letting him know what I felt wasn't something I could forget or ignore.

I just had to find out who he really was and where in the hell I was going to find him.

Chapter Six

Grey

I leaned back on the bench, sweat pouring off me, the music pounding through my earbuds as I focus on the bar above me. I lifted my arms and curled my fingers around the metal, breathed out rapidly for a few seconds, and then lifted the bar and proceeded to do four reps before setting the bar back in place.

I closed my eyes and focused on controlling my breathing, but that, as well as working out, did nothing to dim the racing of my thoughts about Ari. It had only been a couple days since I'd seen Camden, and waiting to hear back from him was hard as fuck. Plus, my incessant texts in these few short days no doubt got on his damn nerves.

But shit, what could I say? Ari had burrowed herself into me and there was no chance of getting her out of my system. I knew for a fact, even more so as time went on. I knew she was meant to be mine, and maybe this fixation on her was fate, the world—hell, fucking destiny if I was going to throw all of those in the ring—telling me I would never be happy until I had her in my life.

I was about to do another set when I heard the music shut off and an incoming call take its place. I sat up and reached for my phone, seeing it was Camden, and everything else faded away as I answered that call quicker than any other fucking thing I'd done in my life.

"Hey, man," I said and grabbed a towel, wiping the sweat from my face. "You got the info on her?" I could hear him typing away on the keyboard.

"Yeah, you impatient bastard." He chuckled softly. "Come on over whenever and I'll show you what I was able to get."

I wanted to demand he just give me her name and number, hell, even her address, right over the phone, but I wouldn't be that much of a prick.

"I'm coming over now."

He snorted. "Of course you are," he teased.

"Asshole," I jabbed back and heard him laugh.

I ended the call and sat there for a second, grinning like a fucking fool. She might not know it yet, but I could finally go after the girl I'd already claimed as mine.

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* * *

"And what if she's with someone? Like, has a fucking boyfriend?"

That very thought had a low rumble leaving me.

Camden sat up straighter and looked around his apartment. "Is there a fucking wild animal loose in here or some shit?" He looked at me once more. "Oh. No, it's just Grey acting weird and primitive as fuck again."

I flipped him off good-naturedly, although I'd been feeling on edge. And the more time that passed, the more I felt that need growing. It clawed inside me, as if trying to get out.

I'd arrived just five minutes ago and waited for Camden to grab a couple beers out of the kitchen and make his way back to the computer. I tried not to hound him, knowing he already thought I'd lost my damn mind.

But now I sat on the couch, bouncing my leg, my forearms resting on my knees and the beer in my hand as I stared at him.

He looked right back at me, a small smirk on his face. I knew he was prolonging this, because he liked seeing me antsy, which hardly ever happened.

"Can I just say, I've never actually seen you like this before." He leaned back, bringing his beer bottle to his mouth and taking a long sip.

I clenched my jaw and forced myself to rest against the back of the chair, to act like I was relaxed, not about to tear through my damn skin.

"Yeah? And what way is that?" Oh, I knew exactly what he was going to say.

Camden shrugged. "I don't know. Strung out? I don't even know if that's the right word. You're acting kind of cavemanish." He chuckled softly and set his beer on the computer desk. "Although I like seeing you squirm, I certainly don't want my ass handed to me because you're impatient, so how about we get right to it?" His chair squeaked as he turned to face the computer and started working, his fingers flying over it, his eyes moving back and forth as he stared at the screen.

I found myself standing and heading over to where he sat, stopping just a foot from him and staring at the computer as well. It looked like a bunch of foreign writing to me. I'd never been one for technology. I was a hands-on type of guy and had focused on building my renovations and handyman business from the ground up. That meant I didn't do much tech savvy stuff on the daily.

I worked with my hands, got dirty. That's who I was.

"Can you let me know what I'm looking at here?"

Camden hit a couple more keys and a new screen popped up.

The breath left me violently when Ari's picture covered half the screen. My heart stopped in that moment as I stared at her. It was her drivers license picture, and a smaller image of her actual license right below that. The information on the right side was basic, like her name, height, weight, and eye

and hair color. Below that, I saw her phone number, birthday, that she was an organ donor, and her material status.

Ari Matthews.

Single.

Although I'd assumed that from the fact that she let me kiss her.

"So I hacked into the DMV and got the basics. But then I did some more digging, because I knew you'd be up my ass about needing anything and everything about her."

Smart man.

"She doesn't have a husband or boyfriend, owns a two-bedroom off Willow Court, modest mortgage. She lives alone, has one cat, got her master's degree at CSU, and is a legit librarian."

I listened to everything he said, absorbed it all, memorized it. I scanned the information from her drivers license.

Brown hair. Blue eyes.

It all sounded so plain, when in fact she had red highlights, her hair the color of roasted chestnuts. And her eyes... her eyes were so much more than just blue. They looked like the ocean.

"So, this the shit you were looking for on her?"

I nodded and then realized he couldn't see me. I clocked him on the shoulder. "Yeah, man. That's exactly what I needed."

And right now, what I needed was to go to her. Might be a little stalkerish, definitely a little alarming for her to have a strange man show up on her doorstep. But I had to see her.

It had been a week too long since I'd seen her, and I was going through withdrawals where Ari was concerned. I just prayed like hell she didn't call the cops on me, because having to walk away from her would be the hardest thing I ever did.

Chapter Seven

Ari

I stood in front of the stove and stirred the can of soup I'd poured into the pot. The wooden ladle was almost mesmerizing as I watched the liquid move in a circular motion.

I had no energy to actually make anything healthy or substantial, or to stop by and pick anything up after work. So after I'd left the library, I headed straight home, made myself a small side salad, grabbed a can of chicken noodle soup with way too much sodium in it, and heated it up.

Definitely not glamorous, but I was tired and sore from shelving books all day and hunching over the computer to catalog shit, so a hot bath and early bedtime was for sure in my near future.

I closed my eyes and tipped my head back, rolling it around on my neck, trying to get the kinks out. I lifted my hand and started gently rubbing my nape, focusing on a couple pressure points, all the while still stirring the soup.

I opened my eyes, turned off the stove, scooped out some of the soup, and put it in my favorite bowl that had a tiny chip on the edge before making my way toward the table. And when I was seated, I just sat there and stared at the wall. A part of me felt a little bit lonely, a little bit sad over the fact that I was once again eating alone at my two-seater dining room table, staring at the sunflower wallpaper across from me. It was the same wallpaper that had been up when I bought the house, and I desperately needed to change it.

I thought about the dress fitting earlier today and how I was definitely going to take the girls' advice and try and find out who he was. Although I had no idea where to start or how to go about it, since I wasn't some experienced spy in hunting people down, I told myself tomorrow after work I'd

head to the bar and ask around. Hell, maybe Grey would even be there.

A girl could hope.

I started eating, admiring the glass of wine in front of me that was white and cold and fruity tasting. I wasn't a huge drinker, but on occasion, a nice glass of chilled Pinot hit the spot. And how glamorous was I, drinking wine and eating canned soup?

I felt something soft move against my bare leg and looked down to see Fluffy, my longhaired calico cat, rubbing up against me. She glanced up, squinting her eyes and giving me a low meow.

"Hey, pretty girl." I scooped her up and set her on my lap, running my hand over her head and sliding it down her back. She gave me a purr of appreciation.

I'd had Fluffy for the past ten years, my solid companion who was always there when I got home, never asked for anything but some food and love, and who never judged when I'd vented to her more times than not.

I snorted at how pathetic I seemed right now.

Fluffy made herself comfortable on my lap, lying down, her purr becoming louder the longer I petted her. I was about to start eating again when I heard three hard raps on my front door.

I turned my head in the direction of the door, despite the fact that I couldn't see it, because the wall was in the way. I felt my brows furrow, wondering who would be at my house. It wasn't exactly late, a little after seven at night, but usually if the girls were coming over they called first.

I set Fluffy on the ground and stood, making my way toward the front door and rising on my toes so I could look out the peephole. And it was that first glance of him on the other side—the man who'd consumed my thoughts for the past week—that had my heart stopping, my body tensing, and everything inside me freezing.

"Oh my God," I whispered.

I had my hands flat on the door, feeling a cold sweat break out over my entire body. My heart seemed to stop then restart, pounding like a freight train.

He was here. Grey was on the other side of my front door. Here. At my house.

I looked around, panic seizing me momentarily.

And all the while, Fluffy happily meowed as if she didn't know I was spazzing out.

I tried to compose myself but failed miserably. And then I reached my hand out and grabbed the handle, turning it but not yet pulling it open. My breath stalled, every muscle in my body tightened, and I seriously thought I'd pass out.

Fluffy purred at my feet, rubbing up against my leg. Did she not realize he was here, like he was actually *here*? Why was I the only one freaking out?

I closed my eyes and shook my head, realizing I was losing my damn mind. And then I opened the door fully, my eyes now open, probably wide as hell, and looked at Grey. He seemed just as stiff as I felt, but in that moment, everything else seemed to fade away.

My nervousness, anxiety, confusion about why he was here... it all vanished, and I was brought back to the bar with his lips on mine and those butterflies in my stomach.

"Ari." He said my name hoarsely, as if he couldn't believe he was standing on my doorstep either.

Then, reality slammed back into me.

I swallowed, my throat feeling tight, this choking sensation moving through me. I didn't respond, because I couldn't find my voice. He stared at me, his big body taking up everything, so much so that I couldn't even see the houses or the street behind him.

"I…." He stopped talking and lifted his hand to rub it over the back of his neck. He glanced away for a moment, and I could see he was trying to think of something else to say. Hell, I didn't even know

what to say.

When he looked back at me, I was caught up in the bright blue color of his eyes, got lost in the sensation of my heart starting and stopping then picking up pace the longer I stood there. I curled my hand tightly around the edge of the door, my nails digging into the wood.

"You're probably wondering who I am and why the hell I'm here." He gave me a nervous half-smirk. "Hell, you probably don't even remember me—"

"I remember you," I blurted out and felt my face heat, my lips tingling. I cleared my throat. "I remember you from the bar." I tried to act collected and calm, but I knew I was failing miserably.

He exhaled, looking... relieved.

It was when the initial shock faded that common sense slammed into me like a jealous bitch, his words playing over and over in my head.

"How did you find me?" I knew I should have been worried, having some strange man I'd shared one kiss with show up on my doorstep. I'd only given him my first name.

A moment of fear consumed me, but as I stared into his warm eyes, saw that he seemed just as unsure as I felt, that fear left me. I didn't know why I wasn't terrified right then, slamming the door in his face and calling the cops. That's what a rational person would've done, right? But I didn't feel those massive red flags going off in me. When I stared at him, I felt like I'd known him my entire life.

I really was losing my mind.

"How did you know where I lived?" I finally found my voice and asked.

He shifted on his feet, that nervousness in him coming out tenfold now. But then he stopped moving, his expression sobering. "Ever since I kissed you, I haven't been able to get you out of my mind, Ari."

He hadn't answered my question, but in that moment, I didn't even care, not as I played his words on repeat in my head.

He took a step toward me. "Please say you felt it too. Please tell me I'm not losing my fucking mind, that you've been thinking about me nonstop too?"

I didn't speak right away, just stood there thinking about what he said. And after a moment, still staying silent, I stepped aside and pulled the door open even wider, letting him inside.

I had to find out why I felt this way with him, even if I still wanted an answer to how he'd found me.

Chapter Eight

Grey

I wouldn't have blamed her if she'd slammed the door in my face and called the cops on my ass. But when she stepped aside to let me in, I felt this massive relief fill me.

I shut the front door and kept my distance, even though all I wanted to do was pull her into my arms and hold her close.

We stood there and stared at each other for long moments, and I was tongue-tied, not knowing what to say now that I was in front of her. I had a whole spiel planned out in my head, having it play on repeat this entire week. But now, here I was, looking at her and feeling all kinds of nervousness, like I was on my first date and scared as hell, not knowing where to start.

But I knew I should answer her question about why I was here, how I'd found her. Although it was kind of an underhanded and dirty tactic, I'd been desperate. And now I was afraid as hell, because being honest might make her tell me to fuck off.

And I couldn't blame her, but I sure as hell hoped that wasn't the case.

"Ever since I kissed you, Ari, you've been on my mind," I said again, really wanting to drill that home. "I was desperate, needing to find out who you were, because I couldn't let you walk away, not when what I felt was unlike anything I'd experienced before." My heart was racing as I spoke the words, told her the truth. "I was willing to do just about anything to get that information, even if that meant going about it the wrong way." Although it didn't feel wrong, because I was head over heels for her and would do anything—even now—to make her mine.

She had yet to say anything, but she wasn't looking freaked out, wasn't demanding I leave, so I

guessed that was a point in my favor.

"So you what, looked me up online with just my first name?" Her voice was level. "And you searched for me only having my first name until you found me?" Her brows rose in surprise, but still she looked like she was right here in this moment with me and not about to tell me to get the fuck out.

I took that as a win.

I shook my head slowly. "No. Yes. Well... I had a buddy of mine find that information, because he's good at hacking into shit." Fuck, I was digging myself a hole right now. "I just meant he's good with computers and stuff, so it took him a couple days, but he was able to give me your name and address, even your phone number." Okay, I knew I was making myself look pretty damn bad right now.

I didn't tell her about all the other shit I'd found about her, like that she was an organ donor, that I knew where she worked, where she'd gone to college, or anything like that. I was probably already setting off red flags.

She was silent for a second, and then I heard her slowly breathe out. "So what you're saying—admitting to—is that you stalked me?" Although she phrased it like a question, we both knew that's exactly what I'd done.

I rubbed the back of my neck again, a nervous habit I was finding out about where she was concerned. Hell, I never got antsy about shit, didn't let anything or anyone get under my skin. But with Ari, I found all of what I thought I knew about myself going right out the damn window.

"Yeah," I said honestly. I wasn't going to lie or sugarcoat it. Hell, I hadn't this far, so why start now? "But I swear I'm not some psycho." I held up my hands in surrender.

She stared at me for long seconds, but then I saw her lips twitch, amusement washing over her face right before she burst out laughing. She covered her face with her hands as she continued to laugh, and I felt my masculinity drop down a couple notches.

"Uh…." I said, not sure how else to respond to this change in the situation.

She dropped her hands back to her sides, wiping the tears out the corner of her eyes before sobering. But she still wore a little smile. "You realize how ridiculous that sounds, right? That you admit to stalking me, but then tell me you're not a psycho?" She lifted one perfectly arched dark eyebrow. "I think stalking is like one of the key points of what a psycho does."

I blinked a few times, processing what she said, then felt a smile spread across my face.

"And I think a psycho would probably say he isn't a psycho."

I was laughing now, realizing how stupid I'd sounded. "Okay, touché. But I don't know what else to say, how to word it to show you I'm not some creepy-ass pervert hunting you down."

Just then, the sound of meowing caught my attention and I glanced down, seeing a calico cat strutting into the foyer. She stopped by Ari's feet, sat down, and just stared at me, as if she were silently judging me because of what an ass I was making myself out to be.

"This is Fluffy," Ari said and bent down to pick up the cat. "She hates everyone." The way she said it to me was almost like a challenge, like if I didn't get the cat's approval then I was out.

I smirked and stepped forward. "Really? Because that purr tells me otherwise," I shot back playfully, lifting a brow as if challenging her as well. While staring into Ari's eyes, I reached out and started petting the cat. She purred louder and rubbed her head against my hand. I smirked, and then, a second later, Ari did the same.

"Traitor," she said under her breath to the cat before setting her on the ground and straightening. I was a couple feet from her still, and it was taking everything in me to stay right where I was. "I've got to be insane," she finally said softly after a few seconds.

I didn't want to say anything and ruin this, so I used all my strength to stand there and let her take the lead.

"Although all of this should have some massive red flags going off, I'd be lying if I didn't admit I've been thinking about you nonstop since that kiss."

My heart momentarily stopped at her words. I forced myself not to make a sound, despite the fact a low growl of approval nearly left me.

"In fact," she said and started acting a little nervous, "I was going to try to get information on you, because it was eating me up not knowing who you were."

"Really?" This surprised the fuck out of me but also pleased me.

She nodded. "Yeah. I was going to start back at the bar and see if I could get any information on you from there." Her cheeks turned this pretty shade of pink. "I thought I was insane, but knowing you were all in stalker mode has made me not feel so crazy."

I chuckled softly. "I swear I've never done anything like this before. Hell, I haven't even been with a woman in far too long to count." Why in the hell had I just admitted that? Like that little fact wouldn't have her wondering what in the hell was wrong with me that I'd stayed away from the opposite sex. "Uh, I just mean, I've been busy working on building my company, so finding female companionship has been on the very bottom of my to-do list." Like the very bottom—bottom of the barrel kind of shit that never saw the light of day.

I was rambling and probably looking even more like an ass.

"Shit," I muttered. "I'm really making this fucking awkward." And there I went, dropping curse words like a sailor who didn't give a shit what she thought about me. "I'm sorry." I shook my head. "I'm nervous as hell and rambling and cursing, and you're probably wishing I'd get the hell out of your house."

Although, I prayed she didn't kick me out.

I stared at her, and after a second, she smiled softly, sweetly.

"Actually," she said, "as crazy as all of this is, I don't want you to go."

I was grinning like a fool then. "Yeah?"

She nodded. "It's insane, given the fact that we don't know each other very well, and not to mention how you looked my information up illegally and then showed up at my house."

I internally grimaced, because that sounded shady as fuck.

"But there's this connection I feel, this pull toward you that makes no sense, isn't rational, and is something I can't push aside."

I did take a step then but kept my hands to myself. "I feel that too. I've never felt anything like this, Ari. I've never wanted someone more in my life than when I saw you step through the door to the bar. I couldn't take my eyes off you." I watched as her eyes dilated, saw her chest starting to rise and fall a little faster.

She lowered her gaze to my mouth, and I tried to hold in the groan that spilled from me. I wanted to kiss her again, desperately, but I knew I was already treading on uneven ground, showing up like this, probably confusing her, scaring her. But she didn't look frightened right now. She looked ready for me, anxious and eager, maybe even desperate for my kiss.

"I assume you know my name, like my full name, so introductions are pointless?" She asked those words low, almost breathily.

I felt myself lean in closer, as if we were two magnets being pulled together. The air stilled, heated, thickened. It was like this plush blanket around us, warming me, making beads of sweat pop out along my body... turning me on.

“Yeah,” I said gruffly, not even sorry anymore I’d gone to these lengths to find her. “But you don’t know me. Who I am.”

Fuck, it felt like I was standing under the summer sun, burning, drenched in sweat, but wanting more.

“I don’t know anything about you, Grey...?”

“Harrison,” I supplied.

“Grey Harrison.”

The way my name rolled off her tongue had my cock jerking.

I felt her hand on my chest, her nails lightly curling into me. This low, gruff sound left me involuntarily, and I held my breath the closer I moved to her.

“Want a drink?” she asked, her voice breaking the silence, her words no more than a whisper, her sweet-smelling breath moving across my lips.

I stayed still, not moving any closer but also not moving backward. My heart was racing, a war drum beating behind my chest, pounding against my ribs. It took all my power to move back and give her space, to force myself to break the spell, albeit momentarily.

I cleared my throat and nodded, curling my hands into tight fists at my sides to stop myself from reaching out and taking hold of her, from pulling her against me and pressing my mouth to hers.

“Yeah, a drink would be good.” Although, I didn’t know if alcohol was the best course of action. It would be like adding gasoline to an already raging open fire.

Chapter Nine

Grey

Nothing like trying to hide a raging boner.

Despite Ari asking if I wanted a drink, we stood there for a few more seconds just staring at each other, our breathing identical. It was fast and harsh, as if we'd run a marathon. Finally, she moved away from me, and I sucked in a harsh breath. Ari glanced over her shoulder, still holding eye contact.

I followed her into the kitchen, rubbing my palms up and down my thighs, my heart racing even though I wasn't near her. I didn't know what kind of spell this woman had on me, but I knew I didn't want it to break, didn't want it to lessen.

I wanted to be lost, drown in it. She was the air I was desperately gasping for.

"Wine or beer?"

"Beer, if you have it."

I stood in the entryway of the kitchen, watching as she walked over to the fridge. She opened it, and I heard the clink of glass hitting glass, and then she produced a beer bottle. Her cheeks were pink, her blush evident. I was doing my best to keep my erection under control, but that was like trying to control a runaway train.

I was thinking of anything and everything I could to make sure the fucker didn't get harder. Because already it was working its way into lead pipe territory. I kept my hands clasped in front of me, trying to hide it, but that was probably making it even more obvious.

She'd grabbed her win glass off the table, and I popped the cap of my beer, started drinking it, and

leaned against the doorframe, watching her. She rested back against the counter, doing the same, her hand wrapped around the stem of her glass, her fingernails painted a light turquoise shade. I couldn't help but stare at them, how delicate her fingers were, long and fragile like little branches.

She made me feel masculine, even more than I already did, with how tiny she was, how she felt pressed against me, all softness and femininity.

I cleared my throat, feeling my cock hardening further, pressing against the zipper of my jeans. I lowered my hands and tried to stand there nonchalantly, the beer bottle in front of my crotch so she couldn't see the reaction I was getting just being around her.

"Maybe we should talk about this more?" Her voice was so fucking feminine it almost made me growl in appreciation.

Talking was the last thing I wanted to do.

She looked at her wine glass. And then she nodded slowly, lifting her head and looking at me in the eyes. "It would probably be the adult thing to do, right?" Ari's little pink tongue moved out and ran along her bottom lip.

I clenched my jaw, feeling that tightness in my muscles surface once again. I pushed away from the wall and glanced over at the table, forcing myself to walk toward it until I was seated. But really, that was just to hide my massive, raging hard-on.

"Yeah, talking would most definitely be the adult thing to do." I had one arm resting on the table, my hand holding the beer bottle, and the other one on my thigh. My palm was curled around my knee, my fingers digging into my leg. I could see her mulling something over, thinking quite hard as she chewed on her bottom lip and kept glancing at me and then away, as if she were shy, as if she knew I would be able to read her mind.

Then she started to move closer to me, and closer, and I shifted on the chair, feeling like something was moving in a totally different direction than I'd anticipated.

And as she came closer, I realized she wasn't going to the seat across from me. She was coming toward me.

I sat up straighter and curled my hand tighter on the beer bottle, my pulse increasing. She stopped when she was just a foot from where I sat, looking down at me, her long, dark hair hanging over her shoulders in loose waves. Her lips parted and her pupils dilated. I watched as her pulse beat rapidly beneath her ear.

Something moved between us, something that felt like electricity on the hair on my arms and left my skin tingling, my cock harder than it had ever been in my life.

"Ari?" My voice was tight and low, almost unintelligible.

"Talking is what we should do, right?" she murmured almost absentmindedly.

I nodded, but talking was the last thing on my mind.

"Because anything else would be insane." She stared into my eyes, and all intelligent thought left me.

"Anything else?" God, I was so turned on right now and she wasn't even touching me.

We didn't speak after that, just kept eye contact with each other, the heat in the room intensifying as if I were in a sauna, as if I was suffocating, but I refused to move. I was stationed right in this very spot.

And then she took another step toward me and I felt the light pressure of her legs against my knees. It was then that I snapped. The primal animal deep inside me, the one I tried to control, to keep on a leash, finally broke free.

I had my hands wrapped around her waist, my fingers digging into her skin. The low sound that

left me had her eyes widening slightly. I was about to apologize, to say something that wouldn't have her running in the other direction, but before any words left me, she lifted her hands and placed them on my shoulders. Her nails bit into my T-shirt-covered skin, causing a shot of lust to slam through me.

Another rough noise spilled from deep within my throat. I found myself sliding my hands over her hips, along the small of her back, and I curled my fingers around the mounds of her ass. The jean shorts she wore were a little obscene, cut off so I had seen the crease where her ass and her legs met as she walked away from me.

And now I felt that fucking hot crease.

I teased the skin right there at the junction, so tempted to move those digits inward, toward her inner thighs, toward her sweet spot. But I held myself firm. There was no reason to rush this.

She was breathing harshly now, her mouth parting even more, her eyes wide. She looked nervous, maybe even a little scared.

"Do you want me to stop?"

She licked her lips and shook her head, but I could see her hands were shaking slightly, could feel how tense she was. And as I stared into her eyes, gauged how she reacted to me, it was then that I realized something about her, about this situation.

Her reaction to me, to my touch...

Fuck. Could she be? Was she?

"Ari." The way I said her name was almost animalistic in nature. But it couldn't be helped. "Have you never been touched?" She didn't speak for a moment, but I could see she was anxious over my question. "Has a man never touched you, baby?" I asked again, lower, slower this time.

She didn't speak for a second, but then finally, she shook her head. Just as slowly as when I'd asked her.

"No." Her voice was so soft I almost didn't hear her response.

A virgin? She was a fucking virgin?

And then without thinking any longer, because at that point all rational thought was gone, I pulled her right onto my lap.

Her legs were on either side of me, her body straddling my thighs, her chest only an inch from mine. Her face was so close I didn't even think a sheet of paper could fit between us. And all I wanted to do was kiss her again. But I waited, seeing what her move would be.

She'd allowed me to pull her on top of me.

Would she let me go further?

Chapter Ten

Ari

I couldn't breathe, couldn't even think straight. I was on top of Grey, straddling him, my legs obscenely spread, the material of my shorts digging into my flesh. The seam was pressed against my pussy, a little bit uncomfortable, but a lot pleasurable.

I had my hands on his shoulders, my nails digging into him as if I couldn't control myself, couldn't stop my reaction to him.

The feel of his hands on my ass had all rational thought leaving me. I'd never been touched before. Not like this. My entire body felt like it was burning alive, like in one single moment I could just detach from myself and nothing else would matter.

"You've never been touched," he said as if he was shocked but pleased at my admission.

I was a virgin, so innocent in most things, but right now all I could think about was all the filthy acts I wanted Grey to do to me.

"I'll be your first," Grey murmured, and my breath hitched.

What did that mean? He sounded so sure of it, so possessive over that fact.

He was so calm and cool in his demeanor. Did he not need me like I desperately needed him? But then he cupped my ass and pulled my lower half over his lap then retreated. Over and over, he did this, slow and easy, and then the very hard, very thick and long rod of his erection rubbed between my thighs.

And all the while he stared at me, never breaking eye contact. He wasn't even breathing hard, his expression like stone, unwavering.

With his hands on my ass, guiding me lightly, I felt him move his fingers to the skin exposed below my shorts, where they had ridden up and everything was almost exposed. I wanted to beg him to touch me more, to slide those fingers closer to the spot that ached so badly I could almost taste it.

But I said nothing, because I was too nervous, too scared that I'd break this spell, ruin what was happening with us right now. I was too inexperienced to know how to talk to a man where sex was concerned. But as I stared at Grey, as I felt him moving me back and forth on him, his denim-covered cock making my pussy cream even more, all I wanted to do was filthy things with him.

Those dirty thoughts and images slammed through my mind on repeat, like a broken record.

And although he looked like he had his shit together, I noticed the little beads of sweat starting to form on his forehead and temples.

He wasn't as in control as he wanted me to think.

He lowered his gaze to my lips, and involuntarily I licked them. I wanted his kiss again, wanted his hands on my naked body, his mouth on every exposed part of me. I was being selfish right now, thinking of all the ways he could pleasure me, of all the ways I wanted him to.

"Grey," I whispered. My body betrayed me, that lone word spilling from me on its own. I had no control right now.

He lifted his gaze from my mouth and looked into my eyes, his pupils dilated, the blue of his irises almost completely swallowed by the darkness of his pupils.

"Ari, tell me what you need." He leaned in even closer, impossibly so.

My breasts were now pressed to his hard chest, my nipples beading up painfully. I knew he could feel them. He still rocked me back and forth on him, and I couldn't breathe, couldn't even think straight. What was I going to say to him? Why had I said his name?

Pleasure built inside me, starting between my legs and shooting outward. God, I thought I was going to come. And then I felt his mouth at my throat, his tongue and lips sucking at my pulse point. I tilted my head back and to the side, closing my eyes and just holding on to him as I started to rock myself against him as well, both of us moving in tandem.

There was no way I could stop this. No way I wanted to.

And then I felt his teeth gently bite my throat and everything else faded away. White-hot heat speared my core, traveling through my arms and legs, through my toes and fingers. Stars danced behind my closed lids, white flashes that blinded me. I heard this sound fill my head, dual sounds, in fact. And I realized it was me crying out as I came and Grey making harsh, almost animalistic grunts against my neck.

And then, when the pleasure dimmed and I started to come back to reality, that high lessening but not extinguishing, only then did I open my eyes. I didn't realize Grey had pulled back, but he was looking at me now with this almost amazed, wondrous expression on his face.

"God, you're gorgeous."

My face felt hot, and I knew the orgasm had made me flushed.

"Was that your first time coming, baby?" His voice was thick and sweet like honey, a purr I felt in every single part of my body.

I don't know why I hesitated, but after a second, I nodded. "Well, with anyone besides myself," I admitted. My face felt hotter.

He groaned right before he slammed his lips on mine, finally giving me that kiss I'd been thinking about for far too long.

Chapter Eleven

Grey

I kissed her brutally, our lips clashing together. I couldn't control myself. I didn't want to. Not when I knew she was a virgin, not when I'd just found out she hadn't gotten an orgasm with anyone but herself.

Those would all be mine. All her firsts, I'd own.

She writhed for me and held on to my biceps with unyielding force. And all I could think of was one thing.

Mine.

A moan left her, and before she could suck in another lungful of air, before she could stop me or I could stop myself, I reached out and smoothed my forearm over the table, pushing everything off of it. I should have been careful, the sound of dishes clattering to the floor loud, but I still didn't stop kissing her.

We stood now, her close to me, the scent of her intoxicating.

I let my gaze move down the length of her body, the hem of her shirt barely touching the waistband of her shorts. I could see a swatch of peachy skin, and my mouth watered. Lowering my gaze even more, I stared between her thighs, needing these fucking shorts off.

"Ari," I groaned.

"Grey," she whispered in return.

"Tell me what you want." I took a step closer, praying like hell she'd let me go further, even if this was just for her.

She didn't say anything, but she did go to the button of her jean shorts, keeping her gaze trained on me as she started to undo it. Then she went for the zipper, pulling it down. My mouth was dry, my cock hard and incessant. I wanted to grab the fucker and start stroking it, relieving the pressure.

"Is this okay?" she asked softly.

All I could do was nod, lift my hand, and run it over my mouth.

She didn't say anything, just pushed those little shorts down her long legs, kicked them aside, and stood there in her top and a pair of innocent little white cotton panties.

Fucking hell. She was perfect.

My gaze was trained on those underwear, picturing what she looked like with them off. My mouth fucking watered for a taste, and I found myself taking another step toward her, and then another. We were an inch away, the scent of her slamming into me and turning me on even more.

"You're looking at me like—"

"Like I'm hungry?" I lifted my gaze to her face. She nodded slowly. "That's because I am, Ari. I'm fucking starving for you." I lifted my hand but stopped right before I touched her, giving her the opportunity to tell me no, to say she wasn't ready, that I was going too fast. But she didn't say any of that. She looked at me like she was desperate for more.

She was breathing heavily, her chest rising and falling rapidly. I let my gaze roam over her body, could see her tight little nipples pressing against the material of her shirt.

My cock jerked again.

Ari breathed out, the soft sound leaving her, causing me to feel feral. I lifted my gaze to her face, which was hard as fuck seeing as all I wanted to do was keep looking at her gorgeous body.

"Baby, I'm on a tightrope right now. Tell me what you want and it's yours." I sounded like a desperate man.

"I need you," she whispered.

Fuck, I needed her too. I leaned in closer so my nose was right by her hair. I inhaled deeply, loving the way she sucked in a breath.

I slid my hands down to her hips, curled my fingers against her warm, soft skin, and growled low. Something snapped in me once more, and without thinking, I lifted her easily and set her on the table, my body between her legs, my hands still on her waist.

"You sure about this?" I asked, although I didn't know what I was asking her for.

She didn't answer right away, just stared at me, breathing hard, as if she didn't know how to answer, what to say.

"We can stop this at any time."

She shook her head instantly. "No. I want this. I want you, Grey. I've never felt this way about someone before, never wanted to share myself with anyone."

I closed my eyes and groaned then found myself sinking to my knees until my face was at the junction between her thighs.

God, I could smell her, this intoxicating sweet and musky scent that had me closing my eyes and groaning in need. Had I ever smelled anything so fucking addicting before?

No. Never.

And I knew I never would.

I glanced up the length of her body, knowing my expression probably looked primal as hell. I sure as fuck felt like a wild animal in front of her.

I needed to taste her.

Badly.

As if my life depended on it.

She had her eyes partially open, slits where I could see the blue of her irises. Her cheeks were flushed, her lips parted. She was right here in the moment with me.

Good.

Moving in closer, I inhaled the sweet yet musky scent of her pussy through her panties. Christ, she smelled delicious. She was addicting, so fucking primed and ready for me. She made me feel drunk off the sight of her, with the smell of her cream, with the fact that she was really going to let me do this.

I ran my tongue first along her left inner thigh and then moved to the other side, wanting to taste every inch of her, memorize her until I couldn't even think straight.

"Ari," I groaned against her flesh.

She had her hands in my hair a second later and tugged at the strands forcefully. I hissed, loving the pain.

I squeezed my hands on her thighs and moaned.

"Grey?" She said my name with a whimper in her voice.

Fuck. I couldn't do this, could I?

While I looked up at her, holding her gaze with mine, I slid my hand to her pussy, hooked my thumb under the edge of her panties, and pulled the material aside.

I tore my gaze from hers, looked at what I'd just exposed by pulling the fabric aside, and a harsh, gruff sound left me almost painfully. I didn't waste another minute. I latched my mouth right over her pussy and sucked. Her pussy lips were swollen from her arousal, and I curled my fingers into the flesh of her thighs even more. I had my mouth on her cunt and suckled on her for long seconds, not wanting to ever stop.

Fuck. So. Damn. Good.

While still licking and sucking at her, I reached between my legs and rubbed my cock, needing some friction, needing to relieve some of the pressure.

"Oh. God." The little mewling noise that left her had me frenzied for her. I couldn't hold back anymore. I really ate her out then.

The sweet flavor of her exploded on my tongue. I licked and sucked at her flesh harder, with more fervor. The sounds she made drove me insane with lust. I tugged at her panties even more, pulling them to the side forcefully. I heard material rending, tearing in half. Her panties hung to the side then, her pussy fully exposed to me.

I lifted my hand that was busy running over my cock and pulled her pussy lips apart with my thumbs, flattening my tongue and slowly dragging it up her slit.

She cried out for me, and I heard the sound of her back hitting the table as she lay back.

I sucked her clit into my mouth at the same time I teased a finger around her tight, virginal hole. I wanted to push the digit in, but I found the strength to control myself.

"Grey." She all but cried out my name, and I renewed my efforts, swallowing her cream, getting drunk off of it.

She was so damn responsive to me.

"Ari, it's so fucking good," I murmured against her soaked flesh, unable to stop myself. I sucked on the hard bundle of nerves at the top of her mound, wanting—needing—her to come.

She gasped out and tugged on my hair even more.

I didn't stop working my mouth on her as she started moving her hips against my face, pushing her pussy to my mouth.

She kept tugging at the strands of my hair forcefully, and I fucking loved it. I started thrusting my hips back and forth, trying to get friction, but there was no relief for me.

God, she tasted so damn good.

I pulled back, which was hard as fuck, and then lifted my gaze up the length of her body. “Watch me, baby. Watch as I lick this pretty pink pussy until you come for me.”

It took her a moment, but she finally rose up on her elbows, looking down at me, her eyes wide as she stared at me, my fingers still spreading her lips.

“Spread as wide as you can, Ari. You know what I want to see.” This vulgar side of me rose up, especially when she did as I said, bracing her feet on the table, opening her legs impossibly wider for me.

And then I looked between her thighs again. God, the way her pussy lips parted, exposing how pink she was for me, had me gnashing my teeth together as all that perfection was revealed.

“God, Ari. That’s such a fucking pretty sight.”

For a moment, all I did was stare at her. I couldn’t move. I was mesmerized, transfixed. I was so fucking turned on I could have come right then and there.

Tonight was about her.

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* * *

Ari

I knew my eyes were wide as I stared at Grey between my legs. God, I was so wet. I wanted nothing more than to feel his powerful body over mine, to feel him stretching me, claiming my virginity. But not tonight. I wanted to get to know him better, for him to know me.

I wanted this to be perfect, even if right now it sure as hell felt like it.

And to be honest, I’d seen myself as the one giving pleasure, taking his erection into my mouth, tasting his flavor as I brought him off.

He stared at me right in the eyes and then placed both his hands under my ass, lifting me to his waiting mouth. Our eyes were locked as he leaned forward again. The feel of his warm breath skating across my exposed pussy could have made me orgasm right then.

He did wicked things to my body with his tongue, with the vibrations from his voice, his groans. He used that muscle to run up my center, swallowing my wetness and causing more to come from me. He was so incredibly slow with his ministrations, so agonizingly deliberate with licking my pussy that I found myself pressing closer to him, trying to tempt him to give me more. I'd never been like this, never even dreamed of acting so out of character and wild with my sexuality. But with Grey, this all felt so... natural.

When he pulled back, breaking the spell he had on me, I groaned out in disappointment.

He panted, those warm streams of air making me shake with need. "I want to go slow, know you need that, Ari, but it's so damn hard controlling myself when you're spread for me and taste so fucking good."

"Who said I want you to be in control?" I was playing with fire, surely. The arousal pounded through my bloodstream, crying out for more.

Grey smoothed his hands up my legs, framing my pussy with his fingers, and resumed licking me. With my eyes closed again, my body aching for that release, I let myself rest back on the table. There was only Grey and me. Right here. Right now.

His tongue moved up and down my slit, teasing my clit on the upstroke and pressing minutely into my hole on the down stroke. I was close to finding that release, so close I could taste it. But he was torturously slow, bringing me close to climax but not exerting enough pressure to actually send me over the edge. Perspiration started to coat my flesh as I tried in vain to hold off on coming, as I tried to prolong this experience. All I wanted to do was grip his head and shove it more deeply between my thighs.

"Do you want to come, Ari?"

He had to know I was perilously close as it was. Maybe he wanted me to beg for it, more than what I already was. Of course I wanted to come; I had him between my legs.

At this point, I would have done anything to feel that crest of pleasure wash over me.

"You know that's what I want, Grey." Those words were nearly a cry, begging.

"Then look at me," he ordered.

And I did just that.

The look he gave me had my entire body tightening. As if he wanted to prolong my torture, I watched in rapt shock as he held my flesh apart with his thumbs and ran his tongue up my center. His big, tanned hands seemed so dark against my pale flesh.

When he reached my clit again, he brought the tiny bud into his mouth and sucked hard. Rhythmic motions had me grinding myself against his mouth. I threw my head back as my whole body tensed. The orgasm that moved through me was intense and heady.

"That's it, Ari. Just let go for me," he said against my flesh, sending vibrations to my core.

I speared my fingers into my hair, tugging at the strands until the pain and pleasure moved into one harmonious moment.

And the entire time, he never stopped sucking on me.

Only when I felt the tremors start to lessen, when I felt my body return to earth, did I sag against the table.

Grey said nothing for long moments, and I pushed myself up, my hair feeling like a wild mess around my head. We stared at each other, this possessive, almost frighteningly intense look on his face.

"Grey?" I whispered.

"This pussy is mine. All. Fucking. Mine. Ari." He stared at my face, showing me how serious he

was.

"Yes," I whispered. "All yours."

He growled in approval when I agreed, when those words spilled from my mouth.

"You're everything I ever imagined, everything I never knew I needed."

My heart thundered.

"Now that I have you, I'm not going anywhere."

Chapter Twelve

Grey

T his was what perfect contentment, what being “home,” meant and felt like. And as crazy as it fucking sounded, because I was a rational man and knew how insane falling for a woman after one kiss was, there was no way I’d question any of this.

It just felt too damn good and right.

I had my arm around Ari’s shoulders, let my fingers trail over her arm, stroking her skin until I felt goose bumps along her flesh. Her hand rested on my abdomen, and I was trying everything in my power to control my arousal. Tonight, I hadn’t planned to do any of that. I’d wanted to talk to her, convince her she was mine. Then, one thing led to another, and I’d found myself between her thighs, lapping up her sweet cream.

My cock was still semi-hard, but this wasn’t about finding my pleasure, especially not after she’d told me how innocent she really was. There was plenty of time for more.

I kept thinking about earlier tonight, when I’d had her on the kitchen table, with my hands on her body, my mouth between her thighs. Her flavor would be forever ingrained in me, every cell in my body igniting because of it. And all it would take was a thought, a memory.

This wasn’t a one-time thing. This wasn’t just a one-off situation with her. I’d gone to great lengths, illegal and questionable, unethical lengths to find her. I wasn’t going to give her up now, and I wanted her to know that. I wanted her to know she was mine from that very first kiss.

We’d finished up in the kitchen a little bit ago and had made our way into the living room. I sat on the couch with her beside me, her legs curled underneath her perfect little ass, her head resting on my

shoulder.

And then I'd just held her for long moments, the pleasure I felt right now so different than the kind I'd gotten when she came against my mouth. This was the kind that a man wanted to feel when he was with the woman he was meant to be with, when he saw a future for himself. And Ari was that woman for me.

"What happens now with us, Grey?"

Her words surprised me. They were spoken softly, hesitantly. The vibrations from her voice moved through my chest. I continued to stroke my fingers up and down her arm, thinking about how to word this, how to make it seem like I wasn't some raging lunatic obsessed with her.

"What do you want to happen?" Every part of my body was tense as I waited for her to answer. She could make or break this with just a few perfectly placed words.

Although I felt a connection between us, one I'd never felt before, never even dreamed I'd experience. Although we'd gotten to this part, and I was pretty sure she was on the same wavelength as me. Letting me hold her had to mean she was right here with me in this moment, in this situation, and wanting everything the same way I did, right?

God, I hoped so.

She shifted beside me and sat up straighter, pulling away from my body. I looked over at her, the light from the TV illuminating the living room in an array of colors. The volume was on low, not too high that it would interrupt our conversation, but not too low we couldn't hear it.

"Tell me what you want, Ari." I wasn't pushy and made sure to keep my voice level, without any of that possessiveness I felt when I was around her.

Maybe I was acting desperate, a little bit crazy, but I didn't fucking care. As long as she became mine, I'd follow her lead.

I saw her throat work as she swallowed, and then she glanced down, worrying her bottom lip with her straight white teeth. I couldn't stop myself from reaching out to tuck a piece of hair behind her ear. She snapped her head up, as if surprised I'd done that.

But then she surprised the hell out of me when she lifted her hand and placed it over mine, which now covered her cheek. We stared at each other for a few moments, and I could see from her expression she was trying to work this out in her mind, maybe about to tell me this wasn't what she wanted, that this was too fast and wild.

I didn't deny I was acting extreme with her.

"What do you want this to be?" She threw the question at me, a nervous look on her face.

I didn't answer right away, just cupped her cheek, felt how soft her skin was, how her warmth spread right through me.

"I think it's obvious what I want." Those words were said low, and for a moment I wondered if I'd said them out loud. "I want you, Ari. I mean, look at the lengths I went just to find out who you were."

I watched her blush and couldn't stop myself from running my thumb over her cheek, moving it down and following the path of her jawline, then moving the pad along her bottom lip.

She parted her lips for me, her breath leaving her softly.

"Let me take you out. Let me make this official." I was trying to be all gentlemanly, and it was hard as fuck. All I wanted to do was claim her... in every single way. "Will you let me do that, Ari?" I loved saying her name.

"I mean, you were the first guy to go down on me, so I should probably let you buy me dinner, right?" Despite the fact that her face was red, no doubt from what she'd just said, I couldn't help but

laugh.

Looked like my girl had one hell of a sense of humor to go along with brains and beauty.

Chapter Thirteen

Ari

Date night: One week later

I couldn't remember the last time I'd had such a good night. Here I was, playing mini golf for the first time—sucking horribly at it—and laughing the entire time.

I focused on the hole I was supposed to hit the ball into, tried to align it, but when I swung my club, the ball bounced off the sidewall and hit the life-sized beaver display chopping on a piece of wood.

"Damn." I glanced over at Grey, who stood a few feet away, this suppressed smirk on his face as he stared at me. "Not too bad, right?" Of course I knew I'd played like shit, but hey, if you couldn't make fun of yourself....

"Baby, if the object of the game was to get as many strokes as possible, you would have nailed it as the victor." He grinned and I did the same, but I also felt myself blush for the hundredth time since I'd met him.

"Smartass," I teased back.

He came up to me and wrapped his arm around my waist, pulling me against him. For a moment, we just stood like that, our golf clubs in our hands, the sound of people all around us reminding me this couldn't be some intimate exchange, no matter how much I wanted it to be.

His expression sobered and he leaned down, now so close to my mouth that we shared the same air.

I wanted to kiss him.

I wanted him to kiss me.

And as if he read my mind, Grey captured my lips with his, giving me what I wanted, what I'd been craving all night.

The kiss was soft and sweet, just a brush of his lips against mine. But I wanted so much more. I opened my mouth, letting him stroke the interior with his tongue, and then he moved his against mine in a sexual embrace.

I was getting worked up. I felt my nipples press against the material of my bra and shirt, felt myself become wet between my thighs. But I pulled back, sucking in a great lungful of air, knowing I had to get control of myself.

In just the short amount of time we'd been seeing each other, I'd fallen head over heels for him. I was consumed, and that long week of waiting for this date, of our schedules aligning just right, had me desiring him even more.

And I knew he felt the same way, saw it in the way he looked at me, felt it in the way he touched me, and heard it in the way he spoke to me.

Our feelings for each other were one and the same. It was this intense exchange of heat and attraction that had me wanting to say screw everything and just give myself to him.

And I wanted to do that, right now, tonight. I wanted Grey to be my first and only. This wasn't just about some insta-lust infatuation. I'd felt that connection the very moment I saw him, and it had only grown.

So tonight was going to be the night.

I wanted it to be. I wanted Grey to be the one.

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* * *

Grey

God, she was even sexy when she was eating a piece of pizza. She had half the slice in her mouth when she glanced up at me, chuckling softly around it. She took a bite and grabbed her napkin, covering her mouth with it, still laughing.

When she swallowed it, she grabbed her water bottle and drank a few sips before setting it down, and yet I still stared at her. I mean, I couldn't help it. She was gorgeous and smart and perfect.

She was mine.

"Do you normally stare at women as they eat, or is that reserved for just the ones you take out on a date?" I could tell she was teasing. She wiped her mouth once more with the napkin.

I'd been done eating for the last five minutes and had just been sitting here staring at her. She fascinated me and she didn't have to say anything, didn't have to do anything.

"Actually, I only reserve that for you."

She gave me the prettiest smile.

For the next twenty minutes, we got to know each other. I didn't hold anything back, didn't sugarcoat my life. I was open and honest with her, telling her how my father had left us, how my mom had worked her ass off when I was little so we could eat and have a roof over our heads. I told Ari about the business she'd ended up starting, just a little landscaping one where she'd plant flowers and mulch.

I told her how that business had been my life, that I'd expanded it after she passed away.

And she listened to me the whole time, her expression showing how invested she was in the conversation.

"What about relationships, connections with people?" She leaned forward, her forearms braced on the table.

I shrugged. "Wasn't a priority. I mean, I had friends, but really I just stuck with myself. Camden was the only one who I really kept in contact with all these years."

"Camden?"

I cleared my throat. "The one I had look you up."

She smirked.

I was thankful as hell she hadn't called the cops on my ass. This whole situation could have turned out on the other end of the spectrum for sure.

"So you built the company up, made your mom proud, but everything else suffered?" There was a touch of sadness in her voice.

My heart started beating harder at how she looked at me, listened to me... knew me. I'd been so right in feeling it, in knowing we were meant to be.

We were just on the same wavelength.

I nodded. "Pretty much, but I don't regret anything."

"Is this what you always envisioned yourself doing?"

I shook my head.

"Not at all. What I really wanted to do was be in the Air Force."

She grinned. "Really? Like *Top Gun*?"

I chuckled. "Top Gun was the Navy." Her cheeks turned pink again.

"Sorry. I'm not the best movie buff." She cleared her throat. "What changed your mind?"

I felt this heavy weight fill me as I thought about the past. "Before my mom got sick, she worked her ass off building her business. But being a single mother—hell, a woman in general—made it hard for her to make it, so to speak. But she never gave up."

Empathy covered Ari's expression.

"I watched her health deteriorate, but she still focused on the business. I actually think it helped prolong her life, gave her a better outlook, and gave her a higher quality of life."

"God, Grey."

I gave her a smile, but I knew it didn't reach my eyes. "But when she was really sick and couldn't do it anymore, I told her I wouldn't let it fail. I told her I'd make it my mission to have it succeed the way she always saw it." I hadn't meant to get so dark and solemn, but I wanted to be honest with Ari. I wanted to tell her everything, show her my life in pictures and words and experiences.

She reached out and took my hand in hers, giving it a light squeeze. "I'm really sorry." She

squeezed my hand again. “I’m sorry you lost your mom. I’m sorry you missed out on making connections with people. But most of all, I’m sorry you had to do it alone.”

I cleared my tight-as-hell throat, feeling like I was getting all choked up.

“But you don’t have to do it alone anymore.”

Her words made my chest hurt, but in a good kind of way. “I don’t have to do it alone anymore?” Of course I knew what she meant, or more, I knew what I *wanted* her to mean, but hearing her say it went a long way in making this night even more fucking incredible.

She gave my hand another squeeze. “You don’t have to do it alone, because I’m here. I want to do all these things with you, Grey. I want to have those experiences and moments with you. I want to be by your side as all of that happens.”

I swear I thought I couldn’t fall more in love with her. And yeah, I fucking loved her.

I leaned in and kissed her then, telling her I loved her without saying the words. I didn’t want to freak her out, not anymore than I already had. I told her without words how one day she’d be my wife, the mother of my children, and the one person I’d always have, always want, right by my side.

Chapter Fourteen

Ari

He pulled his truck to the curb in front of my house, and we sat there in silence for a second. I was nervous, because I knew how I wanted this to go. I glanced over to see him already watching me. The shadows in the interior of the truck played across his body, and my heart raced harder.

"Thank you for tonight. I had a really nice time." I gave him a smile, but it felt forced, a little uncomfortable. It wasn't because that's how I felt toward him, but more so the situation. I wanted to lose my virginity tonight. I wanted to give it to Grey. But how the hell did you bring that up to someone? How did you let it happen naturally?

Maybe it was too soon.

Of course, on the heels of that thought I remembered the night in my kitchen, how he'd eaten me out, gotten me off.

"I had a great time tonight. Thanks for taking me out," I repeated, hearing how tight my voice was.

He smiled and ran his finger along my cheek. "I had a great time too."

He moved another inch closer. I reached out and smoothed my hand along his beard-covered cheek. I couldn't hear anything but my heart beating in my ears, could barely even breathe normally. He was looking at me so intently that I couldn't even think straight.

I felt the air thicken and heat, which had everything to do with the arousal pumping through me, and the electricity in his gaze. He pushed strands of my hair away from my cheek, his fingertips grazing my skin.

This intense need for him to lean in and kiss me was strong. I wanted to say the words, wanted to

plead and beg for him to do just that. I didn't want to cross that line.

He wants me. I can see it, feel it.

He went to pull his hand away, and instinctively I reached out and curled my fingers around his thick wrist.

"I liked you touching me," I found myself saying. "Please don't stop."

He placed his hand back on my cheek, cupping the side of my face. His palm was so big, callused, and masculine. We looked into each other's eyes for long moments, neither of us saying anything. I knew what I wanted to happen, and I desperately needed it to go that route.

"Grey." I whispered his name, not realizing it had spilled from me until it was already out in the open.

And then he pulled me in close—well, as close as we could get sitting in the cab of his truck. My chest pressed to his body, molding to it. I made a small sound, one I couldn't hold in. I tingled between my thighs and felt my nipples harden. I didn't know what was happening, but I didn't want it to stop. I felt fire burning inside me.

"You're so beautiful," he whispered. And then he leaned in even more, pressed his mouth right to mine, and gave me a kiss that made me breathless. It was soft, almost sweet. I could feel the hardness, the tightness in his body. I knew he was holding back. I didn't want that. I wanted to feel his raw power. I wanted to be in bed, with him over me and my virginity being taken by the only man who had ever made me feel alive.

He kissed me harder, adding more pressure. I found myself lifting my arms and wrapping them around his neck, letting myself go in this moment.

"Do you want me to stop?" he asked harshly against my lips. I just shook my head. "If you don't tell me to stop, I won't be able to. I'm too far gone, want you too fucking badly."

Again, I shook my head, unable to actually say the words. He broke away and looked into my eyes, his hand cupping my cheek.

"I don't want you to stop, Grey. I won't tell you to," I finally said. He groaned and slammed his mouth down on mine. I dug my fingernails into his back, pulling him closer. I opened my mouth, and he slipped his tongue inside, stroking mine, making me ache between my thighs.

"Ari," he moaned.

"Grey, let's take this inside," I finally gasped, pulling away from him. I felt my lips swell, felt my cheeks heat. "I need you," I whimpered against his mouth, and he pulled away. My face felt hot, my lips swollen from the blood rushing beneath the surface. "I need all of you." I couldn't believe I was saying the words, but they were out, moving between us, unable to be taken back.

He didn't say anything for long moments, but I could see he was thinking hard, deeply. He still had his hand on my cheek, his thumb stroking right under my eye. "You want me, baby?"

I licked my lips and nodded.

"There's no going back, Ari. No going back."

"Good, because I only see us going forward."

He closed his eyes and exhaled roughly. "God, baby, you can't say that to me. Makes me want to just take you right here, right now."

That was tempting.

He opened his eyes and I felt seriousness come from him. "You're mine," he said with so much determination in his voice there was no doubt in my mind he meant it. "You're mine, and I'm not fucking letting you go. Ever."

My heart did this little hiccup. Good, because I didn't want it any other way.

* * *

Grey

My cock came alert, my heart raced, and every part of me was strung tight.

I looked into her eyes, the blue sweeping me in, holding me down. And once again, I realized this was what being truly alive felt like.

And it was all because of Ari.

I held her tightly to me, kissing her until she was gasping for air, until she was clinging to me. I became primal with her, knowing there'd be no stopping me.

I didn't want to waste anymore time, not when I had Ari so ready and willing for me. I leaned back an inch, our mouths still so close if I said one word, they'd brush together. "I want you forever," I said unapologetically. I slipped my hand behind her head, cupping her nape, keeping her close. This possessive side rose up in me like a hungry beast, refusing to be tamed.

"Grey," she whispered.

"Tell me what you want," I commanded. "Tell me what you need."

A heartbeat of silence passed between us.

"You. I only want and need you, Grey."

And that's exactly what I wanted to hear.

"I want you," she said again.

Her words had me groaning.

This was just the beginning, and no fucking way was I going to stop until Ari was mine irrevocably.

Chapter Fifteen

Ari

I had a hold of Grey's hand as I led him inside my house and right to my bedroom. This felt weird, but in a good way, in a new and exciting kind of way.

Once in the room, I let go of his hand and turned to face him. God, this was really happening. I was really here with Grey, knowing full well what would happen tonight.

I was going to give myself over, bare myself to him in more ways than just being naked. My heart was in my throat, beating wildly, intensely.

He took another step forward, and everything in me tightened almost painfully.

"You look so beautiful," he murmured and lowered his gaze to my lips.

Kiss me.

He groaned, as if I'd said that out loud, and leaned in. Grey kissed me deeply until I couldn't think, couldn't even breathe. The flavor of him was on my lips, ingrained in my taste buds. I was consumed by him.

"I need you," I found myself saying, pressing my breasts to his chest, feeling how hard he was to my softness. Before I knew what was happening, he was breaking the kiss and taking a step back.

"You sure about this?"

I nodded instantly, without any hesitation. I felt like my body was on fire, and it was all from this one moment. I didn't wait for him to make a move. I started going for the button of my pants then pushed those down, taking my panties with them. My shirt was next, and then my bra. Then I stood there completely nude, totally on display for him. My stomach hollowed in and out from my rapid

breathing, and I knew this moment, albeit a little unsure, would be perfect.

Grey would make it so.

"You're not going to leave me standing here naked and alone, are you?" I asked softly, immediately feeling stupid for saying that.

I saw the way his throat worked as he swallowed. And then he shook his head. His movements in removing his clothes were slow, deliberate, as if he didn't want to scare me away. We stood feet apart, like we were afraid to get too close. I watched him take his clothes off, watched as his hard and muscular body was revealed to me.

And then he stood there just as naked as me, neither of us moving, neither of us seeming to breathe. I was staring at his eyes but slowly lowered my gaze down his rippling abdomen and took in his massively huge erection. He was thick and long, the crown slightly wider than the rest of him. I heard this small sound and realized it had come from me.

Before I knew what was happening, he was striding toward me with intent and purpose on his face. He had his hands on my waist and started walking me backward until I felt the mattress hit the back of my knees. I thought he'd push me down, but he surprised me by turning around and sitting himself. Then he pulled me on top of him so I was straddling him, my bare, wet pussy right over his hard cock. He watched me for long seconds, his gaze heavy-lidded, his face and body so masculine I couldn't help but feel so very feminine. I heard him swallow again, could tell he was nervous. But what could he be nervous about?

"It's been years since I've been with a woman, Ari." He spoke softly, his voice deep, husky.

It was hard to believe a man so potent, so attractive and virile, could be celibate. But I loved that about him, was happy to know this would be the first time for both of us, me in general, but Grey for years.

He cupped my cheek and stared into my eyes. "You're the first woman who's ever made me feel alive, who's ever made me want to actually think about the future."

I didn't want to think anymore, didn't want to talk, despite the fact that his words slammed into every empty recess of my body and conformed to them, bringing light into all the dark places.

Giving my body to him, my virginity, was what I wanted to do, and that was going to happen right now.

I was finally getting my happily ever after.

Chapter Sixteen

Grey

I was harder than I'd ever been before, my cock so damn stiff it ached. Having Ari on my lap, her legs spread on either side of my thighs, her chest rising and falling, her breasts brushing along my chest, and that innocent little look on her face had everything inside me going primal. Feral.

I felt crazed.

I reached up and wound my hand in her hair, bringing her forward, so close our mouths nearly touched again. I knew I needed to be gentle, soft, and sweet. This was her first time, after all. "Ari." I groaned her name. "The things I want to do to you, the way I want to make you feel. I'm barely hanging on, baby."

I felt her warm breath brush along my lips. She was getting all nice and primed from this, from what I said. I could feel how wet she was, her pussy cream sliding over my cock, making the fucker jerk in pleasure.

"I don't need gentle because I'm a virgin, Grey," she said softly. "I just want you."

I could have groaned, could have come right then and there.

"But I want to make this perfect for you. I don't want to hurt you."

She shook her head. "Being with you has already made it perfect. And I'm not made of glass. I won't break. I just want you," she repeats.

I did groan then.

I tightened my hold on her hair, an involuntary act because I was getting strung even tighter, worked up even more. I leaned in and rested my forehead against hers. "All I can feel, smell, taste, is

you, Ari." I was barely holding on to my control.

I ran my tongue along her lips and heard her gasp from the act. I groaned, the filthy fucking images slamming into my head on repeat.

"What do you want to do to me?" she whispered.

Christ. She was going to have me coming before I was even in her.

"I want to lick your pussy again, feel you make my face all wet from your arousal. I want to swallow it all, get drunk from it."

God, I had to tense, control myself, or I was going to get off.

She started to rock back and forth on me, her hands on my shoulders, her breathing coming in short pants. It was the kitchen that first night all over again, and fuck if I wasn't ready to have that on repeat.

I kept thinking about how it would feel to have her pussy clenching around my cock, squeezing me until I came.

She kept rocking on me, and I felt beads of sweat dot my forehead as I strained to gather my control, to not shoot my load between her thighs when I wasn't even buried inside her. And when she pressed herself down on me especially hard, I closed my eyes and grunted in pleasure.

"That's it," I found myself saying.

She let her head fall back, closed her eyes.

"Baby, come on, give it up to me." I gripped her waist with both my hands and helped her in her motions.

Back and forth. Harder, faster, adding more pressure.

Her pussy ran over my cock seamlessly. I stared into her face, watching her pleasure morph across her expression, knowing it was because of me, feeling pretty fucking territorial right now.

I was breathing so damn hard.

I wanted to fuck her badly. Now.

"Show me how good it feels for you. Come for me."

And then she did just that.

She had her head tossed back, her mouth parted. She dug her nails into my shoulders, giving in, giving me what I wanted, craved. Watching her come was almost as good as finding my own release.

When her body finally relaxed, I cupped the back of her head and tipped it upward so she was looking at me. She finally opened her eyes, this drugged-like expression on her face. I slammed my mouth on hers, kissing her until she moaned for me. I stroked my tongue along hers, plunged it into her mouth, and made a guttural sound when she sucked on it.

After long moments, she pulled back, her pupils dilated, her body tight on top of mine.

"You want me?"

She ran her tongue over her lips. "Yes."

I lowered my gaze to her mouth, loving that her lips were red and swollen, a light glossy sheen covering them. I lifted my hand and ran my finger over her bottom lip, pulling the flesh slightly down and letting it go so it slipped back into place.

Go slow. Be gentle.

I pushed my thumb between her lips. She sucked on the pad instantly, obeying me.

I would never deny her. Never.

"Are you ready for me, Ari?"

She nodded instantly. "God, yes."

"That's my girl." I grunted those three words out.

I cupped her nape, pulled her in close, and claimed her mouth. I wasn't going to deny either of us any longer. I was surprised I'd lasted this long without coming.

I curled my bigger body around hers and felt her breasts press right to my chest, her nipples hard, like little pink erasers.

When I broke the kiss, I kept my hands on her waist, keeping her right where she was but pressing her down on my dick even harder. I ran my tongue over first her top lip and then did the same to the bottom. She moaned, and I kissed her again, and again, and again.

Over and over, fucking her mouth with my tongue.

I was going to devour her.

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* * *

Ari

He watched me possessively.

"Ari…" The air left me at the way he said my name. "I'm starving for you." He made this low sound deep within his chest. His dick pressed between my thighs, a huge, thick rod that had my pussy clenching. I was seconds away from begging him to be with me already.

My entire body tingled, fire racing along my skin. He lifted his hips up, digging his dick farther against me.

"I should be gentle with you, but God, Ari, I'm losing my control."

I was aroused, wet, ready, aching for him.

He ran his tongue along the arch of my neck, licking, suckling, gently nibbling my flesh, and I tilted my head to the side even more. I was on the verge of getting off again from that alone.

He was all hard, big, and strong, with bulging muscles... and his erection had my inner muscles clenching.

He was all male.

He was all mine.

I was dizzy, light-headed from my desire for him. I couldn't handle much more, yet I didn't want this to stop.

His focus was on my lips.

I reached between us and wrapped my fingers around his shaft, and a guttural groan left him. His cock was thick, too big for my fingers to meet as I held him. I was transfixed at the sight of him, and as I started stroking him gently, staring into his eyes, I heard the change in his breathing.

"Christ," he said hoarsely. "Ari. Damn, that feels good."

I moved my hand faster, my mouth parting as I added more pressure. He closed his eyes, his massive chest rising and falling. I was so wet, so turned on watching him get this pleasure, knowing I was the cause of it. But just as I started moving my hand faster up and down his length, he gently pushed my hand away.

"Ari. Baby. If you keep touching me, I'm liable to explode." He lifted his gaze to my face. "And I don't want this to stop." When he leaned in, his mouth was right by mine. "And like I said before," he whispered, "I want to be inside you when that happens."

I sucked in a deep breath. "Please. Be with me." And then he had his mouth on mine, fucking me with his lips and tongue, forcing me to hold on to him or I'd fall to the ground in a puddle.

I clenched my legs together, trying to stem off the arousal.

"How ready are you for me?"

"Grey, I've been ready for you my entire life," I replied breathlessly.

And I was. I had been.

Chapter Seventeen

Grey

I had her in my arms, turned, and had her back on the mattress a second later.

I forced myself to retreat a step back so I could control myself, so I didn't end the night before it fully began. But now I had to have her. I looked my fill of her, all innocence and vulnerability.

I wanted—needed—to feel her tight virgin pussy squeezing my cock. I wanted her to say she was mine, only mine, while my big, thick cock was shoved deep inside her.

I found myself striding toward her, knowing I probably looked feral in that moment.

"Lie back for me," I demanded. I was barely hanging on as it was.

Once she was back on the bed, I just stared at her, loved that she was waiting for me to take her virginity, to make her come. "Spread for me. Let me see *all* of you."

I reached for my dick, stroking myself.

I was on top of her a second later, had my mouth on her neck, and used my lower half to nudge her thighs open so I could wedge myself between them. I felt her slick folds surround my cock, and I started moving back and forth, working myself between her legs without penetrating her.

Damn, she felt good. Soft and wet. Perfect.

I closed my eyes and groaned. "How does it feel?"

She gasped softly when I nudged her clit. "So good." I opened my eyes to see hers closed, her lips parted.

I reached between our bodies and found her clit, teasing it. And then I ran the pad of my thumb along her pussy hole. She writhed beneath me.

I had to taste her again. The flavor of her pussy was still on my taste buds, driving me crazy, making me crave her.

I moved down the length of her body, unable to help myself. When my face was right by her pretty pink cunt, I placed my hands on her inner thighs and kept her open for me. I was drunk off the scent of her. I lifted my gaze and stared at her.

"You ready, baby?"

She lifted up slightly and nodded. "I want you," she whispered.

If she knew my need for her, she'd be scared as fuck.

I kept my gaze locked on hers as I dragged my tongue through her cleft. I had my hand on her belly, holding her in place as I ate her out. Her flavor exploded along my tongue.

I became a beast then.

Over and over, I licked and sucked on her, knowing I'd never get enough. I wanted to have my face buried between her thighs forever. I started dry humping the bed, unable to help myself. Over and over, I did this, rolling my hips, dragging my cock against the sheets, fucking the bed like I wanted to do with Ari.

Soon.

"I'm coming," she cried out long and loud.

When I felt her body tense and knew she was coming, I sucked her clit hard and rode out the orgasm with her. She had her hands in my hair, pulling at the strands painfully, making my pleasure rise even more. And only when she sagged against the bed did I give her pussy one more long lick before pulling away.

"Take me," she murmured almost sleepily.

I moved up her body. My dick was pressed between her slick folds. I took her mouth in another hard, deep kiss, making her taste herself on my tongue. She dug her nails into my skin, pulling me closer.

She panted against my mouth and spread her legs wider. I pressed my hips farther into hers, my cock sliding right between her pussy lips, along the center of her.

I leaned back, bracing my hands beside her, looking down at her. She was so fucking gorgeous, her pussy pink and wet.

She was all mine. I needed to be inside her. I grabbed my cock and finally placed the tip at her entrance.

"Tell me you're mine, that it'll always be this way."

"Yes, Grey. It'll always be this way."

And then in one swift move, I buried my dick in her wet, tight virgin pussy, breaking through her hymen, claiming it as mine. She gasped, her pain clear. I cupped the side of her face and stilled, letting her get accustomed to my size, to the penetration and intrusion. And when her pussy clenched around my cock, I groaned in brutal pleasure.

She had her arms around my neck, her nails pricking my skin. I hissed, loving the pain. It brought my pleasure higher.

"You doing okay, baby?"

She nodded, her eyes a little wide. "I'm fine. Don't stop."

I rested my forehead against hers and just breathed out slowly as I pulled out then pushed back in with as much gentleness as I could muster.

I started moving in and out of her slowly, trying to pace myself when all I wanted to do was pound the fuck out of her. I felt how wet she'd become for me and heard her breathing change.

I pulled out a little, looked down, and saw her virgin blood streaked along my dick, mixed in with the juiciness of her arousal. I nearly came right then.

In and out.

Slow and easy.

But doing it this way was hard as hell and my control was slipping.

Sweat started to coat my skin, my heart raced, and my balls were drawn up tight. I wanted to come so badly, but I didn't want this to end.

I pushed in deep.

I saw the display of pleasure moving across her face. I pushed into her once more and stilled, feeling her inner muscles relax and contract around me.

"Does it still hurt?"

She shook her head slowly. "It feels good."

And so I started rocking back and forth, pushing my dick into her and pulling it out. And before long, my control was slipping, the pleasure taking over. "I'm going to get off." I gritted my teeth, the words no more than a harsh whisper.

But before I could get off, I wanted her to come first, needing to feel her milking me as she found her ecstasy.

I reached between us and started rubbing her clit.

Back and forth.

Slow circles.

And then I felt her tense beneath me. She tossed her head back, her neck straining, a low cry leaving her. The fact that she was coming for me—because of me—had my self-control slipping.

Only when she relaxed, when her orgasm ended, did I slow my actions.

"Look at me," I demanded but instantly kissed her, trying to be gentle. She deserved that and so much more.

When she opened her eyes and stared into mine, I wanted to tell her I loved her, that I thought I'd fallen in love with her the first time I saw her.

But I said nothing, and instead started to really pump in and out of her, filling her up with my cock, making her mine.

"You feel so fucking good." And then I felt my orgasm rise. I wanted this to last, but I also wanted to shoot my load in her, mark her from the inside out. The pleasure consumed me, took over until I was its slave, until I slammed my dick into her welcoming, tight heat.

Head back, neck arched, I just let go and absorbed it all.

And when the pleasure started to dim, only then did I force my eyes open; only then did I pull out of her pussy and stare between her legs. I watched as my cum spilled from her cunt, slipped down the crease of her ass, and dripped onto the sheets.

When I felt my high start to lessen its control on me, I finally allow myself to fall onto the mattress beside her. I breathed out, my chest rising and falling harshly, sweat covering my body. I couldn't help but stare at her, couldn't help but reach out and pull her against my chest. Possessiveness and a feeling of being territorial when it came to Ari washed through me with so much intensity I knew I'd never be the same after this.

She was mine, whether she really understood that or not.

Ari might have started out being innocent, but I'd changed that. She'd know what it was like to get a little dirty, but only with me.

Pride and pleasure slammed into me, and I couldn't help the sound of raw need that came from

me.

It was territorial, but then again, when it came to Ari, there was no other way for me to be.

Chapter Eighteen

Ari

T hese last couple months, I'd been living in a whirlwind of happiness and contentment, like I'd been dropped into some kind of fairytale. I'd almost been waiting for the other shoe to drop, because surely life couldn't be this incredible, right?

I turned and glanced at Grey, feeling my mouth spread into a smile. Nah, life could definitely be this incredible.

The bumpy road that took us down the long driveway to Grey's house was something I was familiar with, something I got excited about. I loved his house, even considered it home when I was here.

Although we'd been taking things slow—well, as slow as two consenting adults who were madly in love could go—I found myself longing for more, wishing for more. With Grey, he gave me everything I could ever want. He was my first. He'd be my last. He was my only.

Yeah, even I thought it was a little corny, but hell, I was the one living it, so I'd take all the sap and sweetness thrown my way.

And I know he felt the same way about me, we just hadn't actually said the words. Maybe that should change though?

I thought about the future, what it would be like to live together, married... have children. And although I pretty much knew what Grey wanted, I never actually sat down and talked to him about it. I worried he'd think it was rushing, that taking our time was better.

Or maybe it was all in my head.

He came to a stop in front of his house, the ranch-style home having stone pillars supporting the patio roof. The cobblestone entryway had a modern feel to it, but everything else was straight-up rustic and country. He had nearly ten acres surrounding the house, some wooded, the rest fields. But the landscaping around the property was what stood out to me, not just because it was gorgeous, but also because I knew Grey had done it himself.

There were flowering trees, bushes, and even creeping vines along the side of the house. It was all so beautiful, and it was clear how much time and effort he put into it.

He was out of the truck and heading around the front end. I opened my door, about to climb out, when he was right there, helping me down, his hands on my waist.

"Let me be a gentleman to my woman."

I slid down his body, grinning. When my feet were flat on the ground, I tipped my head back to look at him. "Gentleman, my ass. You just wanted to feel my body sliding down yours."

He leaned down and kissed me. "Can't I have both?"

"Absolutely. I'm not complaining," I said and grinned against his mouth.

He took my hand, and we made our way toward the front door. Once inside, we went into the kitchen, where he poured me a glass of wine and got himself a beer.

"What sounds good for dinner tonight?"

He took a drink of his beer and watched me. "You." He said it so seriously I had no doubt he meant that.

I rolled my eyes but felt heat now move through me. "You'll get sick of me before you know it with an appetite like that." I heard him growl and felt my eyes widen.

He was striding toward me, and the grin on his face looked positively wicked. Before he got to me, the sound of shuffling coming closer caught our attention. We looked toward the kitchen entryway.

Pugsley, a little dog Grey had adopted before we'd gotten together, stopped and stared at us for a moment. He was missing one eye, only had three legs, and was pretty damn old, but he was the sweetest, and the way Grey cared for him told me they were the best of friends. Hell, he called Pugsley his buddy.

"Looks like we have an audience."

Grey chuckled and faced me again, wrapping his arms around my waist and pulling me in close.

"Pugsley doesn't care. And I bet if he could talk he'd tell me to go and get the girl."

I smiled and shook my head but wrapped my arms around his neck, pressing my chest up against his.

He leaned in and kissed me, slow and easy, gentle and thorough. And when he pulled back, his expression grew serious, somber almost. I lifted my hand and cupped his cheek, smoothing my palm over his beard, moving my fingers toward his mouth, trailing one along his bottom lip.

"Hey. What's with the expression all of a sudden?" I watched as he swallowed, and then he took a step back.

"I've been doing a lot of thinking, but I don't want to freak you out."

This piqued my curiosity and I stood up straighter. "Well, now you've got me all worried."

"You know I love you, right?"

I nodded and felt some relief fill me. "And I love you." He was silent for a second, and then he started to rub his hands up and down his denim-covered thighs. I knew this was a nervous habit for him.

"I love you so much, Ari. More than I've ever loved anyone or anything in my life."

"Even more than Pugsley?" I teased, trying to lighten the mood.

He looked at the dog in question and smirked. “Well, I mean Pugsley and I are pretty tight.” He looked at me and winked, his smirk growing into a full-blown grin.

Pugsley came hobbling over, sitting beside Grey’s feet and looking up at him, as if daring him to say he loved me more.

I bent down and scooped up the little pug, scratching behind his ear and letting him give me kisses on my cheek. “I thought I was the jealous one,” I said and chuckled when Pugsley barked once.

But Grey looked serious. “I really do love you, Ari. And although I had planned to do this much differently, make it special and romantic, I just don’t want to wait anymore.”

I felt my brows knit, confusion filling me as I set Pugsley down. “What are you talking about?”

And then he was reaching in his pocket to produce a small black velvet box. He sank down to his knee, popped the top of the box, and stretched his arm out, showing me the diamond solitaire.

I instantly covered my mouth with my hands, felt my eyes widen, and forced myself not to cry. “Grey?” His name came from me on a strangled whisper, muffled behind my hands.

“Ari, you are the only woman for me. I knew that from the moment I saw you, from that first kiss, when I felt electricity move through every single part of my body. I knew that when I went to any lengths to find out who you were, where you were, so I could make you mine.”

I dropped my hands to my sides, feeling tears stream down my cheeks. I brushed them away quickly and smiled. Surely he knew I’d say yes. There was no way I would turn him down, not when I loved him as much as I did, not when all I wanted was to spend the rest of my life with him.

“Will you marry me? Will you make me the happiest man on this planet, even though you already have?”

I was nodding before he even finished. “Yes. A hundred times yes.” His grin was infectious.

He stood and took the ring out of the box, tossing the latter onto the counter then taking my hand and slipping the diamond onto my ring finger. It felt heavy and cold but soon warmed. I couldn’t stop looking at it. He cupped my cheeks in his hands, tilted my head back, and I saw how glossy his eyes looked from his unshed tears.

“Yeah?”

I was grinning and nodding. “Absolutely yeah.” I rose on my toes and kissed him, wrapping my arms around his neck and holding him tight. I broke the kiss and rested my head on his shoulder, and all I could do was think about how perfect this moment was.

“I’ve been wanting to do this since that first night I met you. I don’t just want you as my wife, Ari. I want you as my partner, as the mother of my children. I want you by my side always. I want you, because we fit together perfectly. You’re my soulmate.”

I tightened my hold around him and closed my eyes. “I couldn’t have said it better myself.” Here I was, engaged to the man who had stolen my heart, and all of this had started with just a kiss.

Epilogue

Ari

Five years later

Sweat poured off my face, slid down my neck and onto my chest. My face felt hot, was probably red from being out in the sun.

I straightened, the work gloves covering my hands dirty from planting flowers. I lifted my hand to shield my eyes from the sun as I looked around the property for Grey. I saw him over by the chicken coop, holding Myrtle, our little disabled chicken. She ate out of the palm of his hand, pecking away at the grain, knowing she had one hell of a life.

Over the last five years, a lot had happened in our lives. We were married, I was pregnant with our first child, and we'd slowly been making the property and house Grey already had into something more. We were making it into our home.

We'd expanded on the house to add two more bedrooms and had gotten some animals. It was our very own little farm.

I'd never seen myself as a farm girl, but when Grey talked about it, becoming animated and excited, all I could envision was wearing a pair of overalls and work boots and trudging through the property to go take care of the animals.

We first started out with the chickens, built the coop, and it had all grown from that.

Although I'd never been much for chickens, after Grey had brought them home from the hatchery, those little feathery things running around my feet, I instantly fell in love. And it hadn't taken me long to demand they would not be our food, that we could collect the eggs but I wouldn't stand for letting

him slaughter them for meat.

That, I couldn't even stomach.

And he agreed, giving me whatever I wanted, because I knew he hated to see me upset. And that was one of the reasons I loved him so much. He understood me.

When Myrtle came along, a little chick whose life had been almost extinguished because of her ailments, I saw him take to her right away. He spoiled her—that was for sure.

Hell, I'd caught him digging up worms for Myrtle and hand-feeding them to her.

She might not be able to stand upright—one of her legs was permanently outstretched to the side—and she might not even really be able to see well, but whenever he picked her up, she snuggled right against him and knew she had it made.

I looked down at the flower garden in front of me, marigolds on one side, strawberries planted on the other, the little white flowers blooming under the summer sun. There was an array of other flowers scattered around, no rhyme or reason to where they were planted. I just liked them wherever, because they were pretty.

I took my gloves off and wiped my head with my forearm, sweat covering my skin. I hated the summer, if I was being honest. I preferred the cold, dreary days of fall, but a part of me also liked being out here, making the property look beautiful, seeing Grey work with his hands and do masculine things.

The matter wasn't a bad trade-off at all. Seeing him dirty and sweaty, his muscles formed from the manual labor he did for a living, was enough to give a girl heatstroke.

He set Myrtle down, letting her peck at the grass, a small smile on his lips. I could only smirk and shake my head. Never once would I have thought a man like Grey would be so soft, especially toward a chicken. But it was one of his qualities I loved so very much.

He made his way toward me, that smile he wore spreading into a grin when he caught me checking him out. He was in front of me a moment later, his hand on my slowly growing belly, his lips on my no doubt slightly salty lips.

I was dirty, covered in sweat, and probably didn't smell the best, but he didn't seem to care. He ran circles over my five-months-pregnant belly, and I leaned against him.

Here I was, this once shy and virginal librarian, now married to my very own romance book hero and digging in the ground at our farm.

I heard the sound of Fluffy meowing and looked over my shoulder to see her trotting over to us, her long calico coat shining under the sun. She stopped at Grey first and butted up again his leg. I swear, all the animals seemed to flock to him like he was the only person around.

She finally graced me with her presence, and I bent down and scooped her up, scratching behind her ear. Grey put his hand around my waist and kept me close, and then we just looked around the property, seeing all the things we'd done to make it what it was, all the things we still wanted to do.

"Just imagine—this time next year, we'll have a little one with us," he said, softly kissing the top of my head.

"You think she'll be like me or you more?" I placed my hand over his, which still rested on my belly.

"I think she'll be a good mix of both of us, but I hope she looks like you." He smiled sweetly.

I couldn't help but swoon. "It's kind of crazy, isn't it?"

He made a deep sound in his throat and I tipped my head back to look at him.

"No." He shook his head slowly. "Not crazy. It's all so fucking perfect it's kind of scary."

I rose up on my toes to kiss his cheek, his beard underneath my lips soft. "I bet you never thought

you'd be in this situation right now." Grey chuckled softly, although I didn't know if I was sure that was the truth or not.

He was a manly man. He probably always saw himself in this position. Me, on the other hand... not so much.

I'd always hated the heat, hated sweat and dirt and all the things that went along with that. But with Grey by my side, I actually enjoyed them.

Finally, I felt like I was home, and it was because I had a great man standing next to me.

He was silent for a moment, but then he curled his fingers gently around my waist. "You know what I always saw for myself?"

I stared at his profile, and he finally turned his head and looked at me, his blue eyes clear and bright.

"I always saw myself with a good woman by my side. And then I saw you walk through the doors of that bar all those years ago, and I knew you were the one I'd been waiting for. I knew you were the one I was meant to spend my life with."

And there he went... making me fall in love with him all over again.

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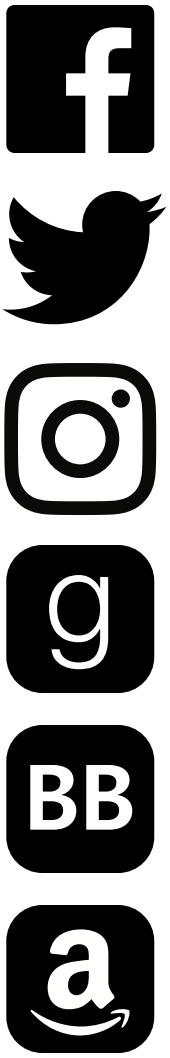
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